Expected consequence

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Adora/Catra

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Catra (She-Ra), Adora (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra), Angella (She-Ra), Lance (She-Ra), Light Hope (She-Ra)

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by Dankteal

Summary

Today was worst day in Catra' life. She lost her tank, she failed her first active duty mission. And she learned what Adora really thinks of her.
"Perfect" Shadow Weaver' pupil run away to side with a bunch of stuck-up rebels at the first possibility. Fortunately Catra got another chance to meet with her. But her former friend believes what everything will be okay if Catra follows her.

Oh, how wrong she is.

Expected consequence

Chapter Notes

Work highly inspirited by Ghost Pupper from @Stedilnik. (NSFW warning. Use your better judgment)

Catra walks through the Woods for some time now. Sky slowly growing darker above the trees. Even less moonlight reaches the ground beneath crowns. By all young cadet knows, she should have been in Fright Zone a long time ago. That damned village wasn't too far from it. Perhaps, treacherous landscape messed her sense of direction.

Finally, gap visible between trees.

When Catra reached it and her eyes adjusted to light, she stopped dead in her track. Brightmoon is standing before her, over the river. No way the Woods directed her here. For a second, she seriously thinks about return to Woods and try her luck again. But, if cadet manages to recon the heart of the Rebellion, the reward would be beyond her imagination. For now. Catra definitely will figure something out upon her return. Besides, she is curious herself. There are no detailed images of the city and its surroundings in the Horde. At least no one has shown them to cadets.

The city located rather by sides of the palace, than around it, big glowing rock float in front of it. Right in the open. Is it completely decorative, or the Rebellion so arrogant, so they leave valuable asset without protection? Judging by lack of any fortifications, it is arrogance. Still, there is only one path inside, if Catra doesn't want to swim across river. And she doesn't.

On the other hand, these morons wouldn't expect to find a Horde member right on their doorstep. She just needs to get rid of all Horde insignias to walk past the guards. Which leaves cadet with

another problem. Her cloth. They couldn’t forbid to wear red color at all, could they?

Catra reached to remove her buckle with a Horde sign from the belt, but hand touched only top of her jumpsuit. She looks down. Her outfit is wrong. The belt is gone. She doesn’t remember her uniform to have so much soot stains and extra holes after short fight with rebels, and cadet wasn’t foolish enough to pick a fight with dump looking giant warrior.

Well. Also, her fur charred in these holes and at some places on her arms. How had she not noticed it before? By the looks, it should hurt badly, but feline doesn’t feel pain. She poked one of the spots on her arm with a claw, trying to get any response. Catra felt only pressure of claw and shift of burned crust, when it gave in to the sharp blade on her finger.

This is bad. If her nerves in this state, she shouldn’t be able to stand at all. And yet cadet walked through rough terrain of Whispering Woods for…

Oh. For how long she has been out there? Catra froze. She can’t remember. Last thing cadet can recall is her escape after… After Adora destroyed the whole Horde platoon! Catra’s platoon! Anger shook her out of stupor. This is some magic trick from rebels, no doubts. Maybe they do have some protection around their base aside Woods.

Whatever. It failed. And her appearance will help her to pretend survivor after Horde attack or something like this.

Catra went to the bridge, but stop when caught her reflection in the water. She got same weird burns on her neck and sides of the head. One especially big wet burn on left side of neck. And her headgear completely black now. Crap, feline will have to steal some paint for it when she gets back home.

After a short walk and ascending the stair Catra finds fist “defence line” of the Rebellion capital. Just two guards. They are wearing

unpractical cloaks and armed with pointy sticks. Neither said anything, as she comes closer. So, cadet decided not to disturb them and went into enemy city.

Entrance into the palace directly ahead of her. It is tempting to go inside. Catra knows better. She needs more options to get away, if things go south. She'll stick with exploring the streets for now.

More stairs. Downhill this time. After descending Catra end up in a big square with a statue of some certainly regal jerk at the center. Not so much people strolling around. Though a group of kids sits in semi-circle in the corner. Feline overheard as someone telling the story to them.

"… We stood up against the Horde to protect people and save their home…"

Great, more propagandistic history classes. She fed up with Horde versions of it. And not planning to hear "different angle" that exclusively favoring the other side. Albeit voice sounds a bit familiar.

"… frontier village Thamor!"

Okay, Catra going to see, who is so brave when got giant warrior on his side. She cautiously walked closer to the crowd until managed to make out person in the center. It is that rebel with arrows from before. Surprisingly, no marks, that she gave him during battle. He is too preoccupied boasting about great rebel fighters, notably himself, and didn't notice Horde scout yet.

Possibly, boy could lead her to the rebel's equivalent of barracks, or other military facility, after he finishes. Catra will wait until then. In comfier place. Like catwalk with chairs directly above bowman. Small detour in the alley, quick climb on the roof and she is ready to hear the rest of his brag.

The boy going on and on and on. He even has shown a demonstration with his weapon at some point and made colorful

explosions with his arrows. It may take more time, than cadet thought.

"…And then we sighted as insidious monster snuck up behind She-Ra and stabbed her in the back!"

"What's not how it was." Catra said it aloud, didn't she? Luckily, no one seems to hear it. The boy's story gets on her nerves already, but when he started praising betrayal of everything and everyone in favour of shiny sword, Catra felt strong urge to come down and beat him to the ground again, like in the village.

"Princess took She-Ra into safety to recover. And I stayed behind to make sure this beast won't follow them. I shot her with my trusty net arrow, but she ripped it apart in a second and run right toward me. Sadly, it was last arrow. Two hundred more Horde soldiers surrounded me. And then She-Ra came and saved the day."

This is just plain annoying now. Feline started to look for something to shut up boy earlier. Flower pot on the railing would work. A hospital is strategic target too, after all.

"… And I can show you the great She-Ra right now!"

What? Is she here? No, young fighter grabbed his tablet, screen facing kids. When he got time to take photos? While Whispering Woods were messing with Catra, that's then. Pot doesn't budge. Cadet pushed it again with all her might. The pot went flying a little too far, narrowly missed the boy's head and crashed his pad in pieces. Catra recoiled from the railing and get down. Yelp comes from below. Some kids get scared and started crying.

"Whoa..!" His eyes should be on the catwalk now.

"Ugh, all calm down, I am fine." What a pity.

"I will tell you rest of the story tomorrow. Okay? I promise."

***

Catra felt as something leaked from her neck on the floor. She pulls her arm to the damp spot and then put her hand up to eyes. Blood. Not much, but nonetheless. Burned spots on arm grew bigger. Magic must be started affecting her more, causing this trick. Catra recognizes illusion when sees one. Some of Shadow Weaver's illusions touchable, but none of them have a smell. And feline doesn't smell blood.

Or anything. This discovery throws her off balance. Catra was too excited with possibility to get some intel on Brightmoon to acknowledge it up to this point. Why can't rebels just build walls around their home, and don't deal with magic garbage? Because this is totally part of magic crap. Even when Catra was sick her senses weren't so dulled.

If to think about it, burned spots resembled ones from Shadow Weaver's "lessons" too, only bigger. Suddenly Catra remembers. She was in the barrack after her failure in village, Shadow Weaver looming over her, talking about it. Catra felt scared. Nothing after this. Did she really say that defecting to the Rebellion was a right idea?

It completely ruined feline's mood. And if Catra was in Fright Zone, that she was doing in the Woods again? Whatever it was, now Catra is here and she got task on hands. Where did the archer went? Cadet spotted him, heading to long, long stair, back to the palace, his arms filled with pieces of the device. Don't rebels know what elevators exist?

By the time they reached the palace entrance daymoon fell behind the edge of horizon. Bowman went past guardians through the front door. Looking for him in unfamiliar building would be difficult, if she takes another path inside. Especially as feline can't catch his smell. Going inside still dangerous. But wandering in it aimlessly one thing. Going at certain location quite another matter. She went after the boy. Once again guards paid her no attention.

Catra pursued boy from some distance. While pair walked, crystals in hallways started to radiate soft light, which closer to natural than artificial. They a little resembled big rock outside the palace. Archer humming some tune, seemingly recovered from misfortune with his pad.

Archer made the last turn, walked inside workshop, dropped the remains of device on a bench, sat down and begun salvaging them for useful parts. Catra will return here, after he go away, to see what else can be wrecked. Meanwhile, she'll explore the palace.

Somehow it even more boring than corridors in Fright Zone. All hallways in perfect geometric shapes. Like this place have been built in one go and never changed since. The easier it is to remember the layout. But big open spaces make her uncomfortable. Cadet trying to keep a low profile here, you know. Well into night, it's simpler to do, however she sees people here and there. And once Catra recognized one person in a hallway as Queen, feline quickly went away from her.

Her wandering disrupted by loud snores behind one of the doors. It rumbles almost like transporter engine. It attracted feline attention. She soundlessly opened door, which unexpectedly hard to move, and peeked inside.

Room occur to be full of purple and pink. Big cagelike furniture, but without burs, attached with rope to the ceiling, hanging in the center. Source of snores inside it on a top of plush mattress. It is the princess. Catra met her in the village.

And the worst thing that nay, she is in this state, Catra can't do anything to the princess without consequences. Or could she?

Feline silently climbed on the top of bunklike structure. She unsheathed claws. They sliced through the rope, leaving around a quarter of its thickness. Catra quietly leaves the room after. She waited in the hallway corner near room until rope gave in and the cage fell on the floor. Princess woke up with a high-pitched

squeak. Catra get away from there at the tempo slightly below running, grinning.

Catra kind of hoped what if both idiots in the palace, then Adora would be here too. She never found her during night walk. Maybe they fooled her friend about how welcomed the Rebellion is, and now she is languishing in some very purple cell. Serves her right.

Moonrise caught Catra on the palace roof. It looks very unlike the one in Fright Zone. At first horizon turned red. Secondly, thin yellow strip raised in the core of more pinkish stain in the sky. It grew bigger and bigger until become full circle. Feline never saw something like this.

Morning took magic illusion from Catra's appearance. But sense of smell didn't return.

***

The first proper day as a rebel is strange. It started deep in the night with destruction of uncomfortably soft bed. Next, Adora went to Glimmer's room and found her bed destroyed too. Glimmer is absent. Former Horde Force Captain has no other choice but interrogate the nearest guard to know what happened. However, she properly apologized to her after.

When Adora heard what princess went to Queen chamber, she ran there as fast as she could, and nearly stormed the place. Sleepy Glimmer opened doors herself and calmed Adora down. She ended up back in her room, beat up rest of feathers out of her mattress, before succumbing to sleep.

Currently, she is trying to "breakfast" with her new friends in the dining room. Conception of several meals per day is novel to Adora. And having extra free time before her duties too.

On a way to the table, with a tray in hands, she caught some red blur in her peripheral vision. But when Adora looked directly, it

completely disappeared. Anyhow, this made soldier realize that there is nothing red in Brightmoon, except her jacket.

She sat down to their place.

“Glimmer, what’s the deal with red color in Brightmoon? Even your food in all colors, but red. Is it like prohibited or something?” Adora meant it partly as a joke.

“Actually, yeah. After the war started, to prevent infiltrations of enemy spies, mom prohibited its usage in the kingdom. And citizens took this edict excessively serious.”

“But why no one said anything about it to me before?” What spies just could use stolen cloth essential too. She’ll raise the issue at war meeting.

Glimmer laughed.

“You are She-Ra, only the queen can tell you what to do or wear. And mom doesn’t think it’s so important, if she didn’t say anything.”

This makes sense to Adora. Although idea that she is second only to Queen Angella in the Rebellion a little disturbing.

“So, since we are talking about my mom, why have you tried to bust down doors to her room?”

The Rebellion is not the Horde, Adora keeps telling herself. And in the same time not very different. Adora still confused about what have stayed the same and what have not. True answer wouldn’t hurt anyway, at least to friends.

“In the Horde, when your commanding officer summons you to her chamber you are in trouble. I tried to help you.”

Glimmer choked. After clearing her throat, she said:

“She is my mom! What do you think she was going to do with me? Besides, she doesn’t even use her bedroom.”

The question is strange. Like what happen, if you don’t take care of your equipment, or if you aren’t doing your drills, or if you get caught stealing extra ration. Everyone knows. No need to say it out loud. Apparently, not in the Rebellion.

“Shadow Weaver would electrocute you until you blackout for letting Horde property under your responsibility get destroyed.”

Wild looks from her friends telling her, that they didn’t expect this as an answer. Ugh, it only getting worse. Maybe ask them next time, if they really want to know about life in the Horde?

Bow is less talkative today, but decided what it is his turn to participate in conservation. He seems concerned, like it not just how life is.

“And how often it happened with you..?”

“Bow!!!” Glimmer interrupted him.

“What? We can’t help her if we don’t know.”

“Never with me. She lashed out mostly on…” Adora’s voice drowned in the rattling of trays pile falling to the floor. The trio get distracted with incident, kitchen stuff started picking trays up.

“Help with what exactly?” Adora said after a pause.

Glimmer copied Bow’s worried countenance.

“Bow, Adora, we will sort it out, just not that early in the morning.”

***

Meeting with the Rebellion command wasn’t very good. Turns out what Bow’s workshop was destroyed by fire during last night. And

Queen deferred Glimmer's suggestion about rebuilding Alliance, until they properly investigate it. Princess gets upset and left. Bow went after Glimmer, to soothe her.

Which left Adora alone for the rest of the day. Without anything to do. Maybe, she could train with the sword. No, Adora's friends told her its unhealthy to spend so much time on it. On the other hand, they are not here.

She recalled Glimmer suggested her tour around the city. It sounded as recon. Yeah, recon is good, and neither of the rebels said anything bad about it.

Adora already asked Glimmer about interesting places in Brightmoon. And translated its names into simple language. Like "park" is a part of woods inside the city, but with clear paths and non-moving trees. Adora decided to start from there.

***

As Catra couldn't find Adora while have searched the palace herself, then she can wait until defector reveals herself. Adora has to come into the mess hall. Or guards would take food for the prisoner.

Her patience was rewarded. Adora came here. Along with her new friends. Doesn't matter, Catra will talk with her later. Cadet can just listen to their conversation for time being.

Catra had this coming for a long time. She lost it when they decided to discuss damned Shadow Weaver. Now just the worst moment she could ever think of for it. And Adora nearly noticed her, but feline managed to jump under counter before this happened.

People on distribution duty decided to help her for some reasons. They not only didn't rat her out, but even didn't say anything to her. Perhaps, rebels know when to mind their own business better

than horders. When they aren't kidnapping your most close person, that's it.

No. Even these hypocrites can't be this nice. Something doesn't add up. Catra just can't understand that specifically abnormal, on top of nicety.

Self-proclaimed spy followed Adora to Rebellion command room and waited for her outside. After rebels finished planning session, Catra pursued Adora, maintaining a certain distance between them.

They ended up in a patch of woods, isolated inside the city. She made sure no one was near, before letting Adora see her. It is only between them. Catra climbed a tree further down her friends track and hid on one of lower branch, so it would be up to her to start the talk.

"Hey, Adora."

Blondie's head jerked up.

"Hey yourself." Not reaction Catra expected. She passed through Whispering Woods to get here for Horde sake.

"Huh, not so happy to see me? But I'm here just like you wanted." If Adora try to hand over cadet to rebels, her escape would be difficult.

"What are you doing here? You made yourself clear about joining the Rebellion." Adora sounds angry.

"Maybe I changed my mind" Cadet does remember what witch did something to her after she returned. And Adora made sure, that it couldn't turn out for Catra any other way. But now she has valuable information. Feline planning to go back when she's done messing with Adora.

"Really?" Blondie's tone shifted. She is hopeful, yet surprised.

“Let’s say I’ll give it a shot. If you convince me about it today, tomorrow I’ll go sign up.” Or Catra can pretend for one last day that things between them same as they were. Before she’ll do the same thing as Adora.

“No subversive plans? No attempts to return me in the Horde?” Feline could knock out blondie, but drag heavy soldier all the way in Fright Zone is impossible.

“Only if you’ll keep rebels from our last meeting out of it. Just you and me for today” They got no opportunity to do such a thing after their full-time drills begun.

“One thing, before we go. How you found me?”

“Only you would wear Horde uniform in Brightmoon. It was too easy.” Adora wouldn’t be glad, if she knew what Catra was swanning around her for half of the day.

“You're one to talk.” Adora smirked. “Anyway, I planned to go check what “bazaar” is next.”

“Well, come on, then.”

Bazaar not very populated during noon. Civilians mostly staying in the shades, hiding from the heat. These, who aren’t, slowly coursing between stalls. Weather in Brightmoon remarkably unfriendly by Catra’s opinion. She thought, what days would just be lighter and the air would be easier to breath without smoke outside. Nothing can be perfect, as it seems.

“Did you come up with something to make me go along with their “Power of Magic” and “Friendship is Friendship” stuff?”

“Yes!” Adora smiled cheerfully. “In the Rebellion, they have “lunch” about now, and… I was told what people giving all kinds of things at the “bazaar” in exchange for “money”, and I think you can try food what is not bar-shaped.”

Her friend carefully pronounced unusual for her words, which was kind of cute. Also, Catra get the idea who explained bazaar to Adora, but the young girl is glad, what she decided not mention them.

Counters with food appears to be not very tempting for feline. Adora touts every food, she knows the name of. But without smell it looks dull. In addition, Catra isn't hungry. Nevertheless, seeing as Adora trying so hard to figure out what she would like feels good.

At some point they walked to the end of trade row. Last stall looks new, on contrary to previous. Middle-aged cervid napping behind it. Adora is radiating with determination not to waste her last chance to find something nice for Catra. They came closer. Blondie kept chirping about wares, while feline started to recall this particular man.

She drove a tank straight through the house this guy was hiding in. Unlikely, that he would recognize her. But their day was good so far, and Catra doesn't want to risk it.

"Can you help me to pick something to my friend here?" Adora's question interrupted her train of thought.

Catra wants to vanish into thin air right now. She'd rather avoid making a scene. Too late to run away. The guy opened his eyes.

"Does your friend have any preferences?"

Adora turned her head to Catra. "Catra, what would you…" She stops short. Blondie is looking confused. She turned back to cervid.

"Eh, sorry, she was right here, I'll find her and we'll come again." What? She is standing at the same place.

"As you wish." Guy returns to his original state. Adora has begun to spin around, then picked seemingly random direction and went in there.

As fun as this situation can be, but Adora will think that Catra ditched her, if she doesn't make her appearance. Or is this hoax? Catra didn't payed attention for that blondie was talking for a few stalls at the end. Anyhow, her friend running away in good speed. Feline need to hurry to catch up with her.

They made it for a dozen blocks, when Adora stopped in the middle of the street and shouted.

"Catra!" her voice a little anxious. This is not a joke.

"What's wrong with you? I was right here, and you suddenly ran away!" Adora turned in her direction. Great, she can hear her. And see.

"No, what's wrong with you? And it's you just disappeared when I wasn't looking." So much for her wanting to evade a fight. Blondie won't believe Catra, if she tells her what feline was standing right there. Faster to go along with it, and have at least partly good time.

"Fine, it was a guy from the village, he could recognize me. This would go bad." Adora calmed after explanation. Maybe she doesn't want to argue over this too.

"I understand." Adora sigh. "You didn't even get to taste anything. They give out food at the dining hall in the evening, how about we try it then?"

"Okay. Any ideas what to do meanwhile?" Tension between them almost evaporated.

"Hmm, I have my own room now. We may go in there and you can check out how people live in Brightmoon. If you join the Rebellion, they'll give you one, too."

"Good enough." Catra went around the whole palace during night and hasn't found Adora's place. She is curious where could it be.

On a way to the palace they kept quiet. Just enjoying each other company.

***

The pair's path led them near ruined workshop. Awkward. Adora gave her a look, yet remained silent.

"Yes. I did it." Cadet appreciates friend's effort to keep her words. But in this case, it would haunt Adora until she knows the truth.

"Why?" Blondie sounds disappointed in Catra.

"You guys wrecked my tank, I liked it, now we are even." Feline was really delighted when she got permission to drive tank on the mission. Who knows if she gets another chance to ride?

"You were destroying the settlement. What I was supposed to do?" Catra regret her choice to raise this topic. Things can't go back, don't they? Answering this wouldn't do any good.

Another long pause. Less pleasant than previous one.

They passed hallway where Catra noticed Queen. So, that's why she couldn't find the room.

Adora's room big as whole barrack and it has own access to the catwalk outside. Her bunk has some holes from stabbing. Useless trinkets arranged across the room without a system. Looks like the certain tidy person just moved in. And didn't have time to redo it in her way.

Catra immediately went outside to check out the view. Adora joined her. The scenery is very different from their hideout in Fright Zone. They are different as well.

"I meant it. What could I have done for you in the village, returning in the Horde excluding?" Catra doesn't know. She

doesn’t see how things could go any other way. Adora just does whatever she was told to by anyone, except for Catra.

It is almost as if Adora think that the young girl will keep her part of promise, even if Adora doesn’t. Black dots on Catra’s arms are back. They are barely discernible. Dumb princesses magic. Dumb magic sword. Dumb Adora.

Catra got her composure together, at least externally. “Nothing. You can start to make up for it, though. By showing me best lookout in the city you know about.” She is trying to sound half-seriously.

“One of the spires on the palace’s side is decent. We’ll need to climb in there.” Adora, eager to do fix things between them, returned into the room.

“Okay, just give me a minute.” She’ll get better after letting out anger. And a place where no one could disturb Catra would help her even more.

She punched a wall on left side of the catwalk. Fist encountered no resistance. She turned her head at it. Catra’s hand inside the wall. She pulled arm away. It gets out easily, no signs of the incident remained.

Feline started freaking out. She tried again. Hand slipped inside. Got out in the same manner. She’ll need more than a minute. Something is wrong with her. And it could only happen during memory lapse, thus while she wandered in the Woods. Or Shadow Weaver has done it to her.

Uh. Witch was furious after Catra talked back to her. Now cadet remembered that officer took her in Black Garnet chamber. She pinned cadet to stone in the center with shadows. And begun one of her “lessons”. It was more terrible than before. She smelled smoke. Then darkness clung over her vision. Something burst on the side of her neck. But the pain kept getting worse.

Next thing Catra knows, she walks through Whispering Woods near rebel's home base.

Shadow Weaver told stories about vengeful spirits to little cadets before curfew. Catra never believed in ghosts. She knew, that witch probably retelling her own doings. But feline noticed a pattern.

Catra didn't eat for three days and doesn't feel hunger. She interacted with objects only when concentrated on it. Everyone ignored her, even Adora at one point. Feline focused on her sense of smell. Yep, it works when Catra thinks that she should smell something. Also, burns, what show up randomly.

Vengeful part is more complicated. Catra had urge to kill a few people. But she wanted to make rebels pay since village.

Everything points to oblivious conclusion. She is dead.

Catra screwed one last time. Most important time. Apparently, she IS nothing without Adora. Nobody needs her the second she defected.

"Are you okay? It's been a while already." No, she isn't.

"I'm fine. Let's go climb that spire or whatever." But Catra has a question.

***

Platform with a place to sit down located high on the spire. Catra is not in a mood for climbing. Feline just appeared on top of it, when Adora left her out of sight.

It took some time for Adora to reach the place. And to catch her breath. Is she tried to race here?

"Wow, you are fast." Like before, but today it caused by different reason.

Ghosts have nothing to fear. Catra thinks what she already knows the answer to her question. But the young girl wants to hear it from Adora herself.

“What do you think happened to me, when I returned to Fright Zone empty handed?” Not The Question, yet important. She needs Adora to be honest for it. Catra needs her to understand what deserter has done.

“You didn't have to.” Adora gets discouraged.

“This is not an answer.”

“Why are you asking? You are here now. With me. Shadow Weaver…” Catra is asking this because she can't just tell her what she wants to ask. Girl warming-up herself before it.

“Shadow Weaver was going to have my head. Which part of it you didn’t understand?” Catra interrupted her.

“You returned to her on your own will.” Like hell she got other choice. No one defected from the Horde before. And Catra doesn’t have a magic sword herself to please the Rebellion’s hypocrites. This day is a farce, they would never let her in.

“What? You thought what I wanted to throw away everything I worked so hard for? And our dream?”

“I wanted you to come with me.” Adora’s face begging her to stop this. Is she thinking for real, what only because Catra is here, they are fine? “I thought you want to get away from the Horde too.”

“And you decided what siccing rebels on me will help you to persuade me?”

“You hated Fright Zone, most of other cadets, and Shadow Weaver never valued your effort. Why would you wanted to stay in there?!”

“She never valued me only because of you!”

“If you hate me so much, why you came here?!” Adora on the verge of hysteria. Catra too.

She has to say it or this will not go anywhere. Catra understood the reason why she is here somewhere along the way to the spire. Though, the young girl had this feeling for a long time.

“I love you, that’s why!” The Question. She isn’t asking, but expect an answer.

“You what..?” Adora doesn’t believe.

“What you heard!” Catra is screaming internally.

“But then why didn’t you…”

“If this is all you have to say to me then go away. Again.” Burned dots enlarged.

Adora doesn’t move.

“I will not return to Fright Zone, if that is what you fear. I can’t.” Or can. This is still senseless.

“Just go away.” She repeated.

“Go away from me!” Catra cried out.

This got defector to leave. She started to climb down without a word.

Adora didn’t have the decency to say in her face what she doesn’t love her back. This frustrated Catra most of all. That Adora always trying to have everything. And then she is forced to choose she never picked Catra, until she comes to Adora herself.

Ghost feel the pain inside like she in Black Garnet chamber all over again. Burning sensation across her whole body.

Catra is angry at herself for coming to Adora. She doesn’t want to love her. And she can’t stop doing it. This is endless torture.

Literally.

Charred spots blended in single black crust coat. Her sight flickered for a second. Blood starts dripping off opened wound on the side of the neck. Hairs matted and scorched on the tips now.

Catra is mourning herself. Each thing she wanted to do. Each lost possibility.

Her second evening among enemies begun and ended.

Adora still doesn’t understand the depths of her treachery. Catra will show her.

***

Adora has trouble with sleep since she found the sword. It was visions first, unaccustomed bed and lack of other people around now. Her worries about Catra didn’t help either. And other thoughts about her best friend, too.

Thus, she notices someone’s silhouette through the curtain over bed, deep into the night. It moved soundlessly around the room. It's dark in the room. She can’t discern details.

Adora retrieved dagger from under pillow in a second. Intruder walked to the balcony.

Soldier got up on her feet and cautiously went after. She stepped in wet trail on the floor. Liquid is cold. Adora re-examines her room. The trail stretches from the doors, turns near the waterfall and lead to the balcony.

When she sees the figure directly, Adora is able to distinguish more parts of it. It vaguely resembles Catra, but not quite. The figure looks smoother in dark places and rougher where light touches it. Also, Catra’s hairs wilder. It stands back to Adora, so it's hard to say for sure, if it’s her.

“How did you get in and what do you need?” She locked the door before going to sleep. Catra told Adora to give her space. She wouldn’t… No. Bursting into Adora’s room in the dead of night sounds exactly like something Catra would do. Adora eased up. A little.

“Catra is it you?” Silence.

Adora took a couple steps closer. She begins smelling smoke. And it seems what feline’s cloth black not due to the shadows, but in this color for real.

Adora got suspicious. Something's up. She comes closer.

“Stay there you are.” Voice is hoarse, she almost coughing words. Still, it’s definitely Catra.

Adora stops, her friend just out of reach. She noticed small puddle at the end of wet trail, under Catra. Soldier sharply inhaled.

“What do you think happened to me, when I returned to Fright Zone empty handed?” Catra spoke first. “You never answered the question.”

“I…” Adora tried to speak, but Catra interrupted her. “Then I’ll tell you what happened.”

“Shadow Weaver burned me to ashes. I never made it out of Fright Zone.” Nonsense. Catra is standing right in front of her.

“Absurd. That have you done to yourself? You were okay a few hours earlier.” Adora really concerned. But Catra hasn’t accepted her help for a long time, if Adora offered it softly.

Catra chuckled. It’s miserable sound.

"I did nothing to myself."

Catra turned, making face visible. Ears scorched, shrank to half their original size. Chalk of flesh missing on her neck, leaving a

bleeding gash. And her eye sockets now math. Nothing inside them.

“But you broke our promise.”

Morphine

Chapter Notes

> Music is helping get in tune with the story. I'll use these mark at the places where it feel needed.
> [1]Friend or Foe - t.A.T.u

Northern Reach is a barren place. No one wants to be here willingly. Too cold to live. No resources to gather. Icy landscape as far as the eye can see. Ocean around the coast full of icebergs. It’s hard to find safe harbor to go ashore. Clefts in ice sheet and heavy snowfalls would make life of any visitor very hard.

Perfect place for Catra. She wanted to be away from living world. She walked long weeks to get in there. And continued her journey after. Step by step. Trivial task to occupy thoughts. Ghost doesn’t know if moving her legs necessary in her state, but it feels habitually. A few times she lied down on drifting ice in the water and just watched in the sky for days.

Catra pretends what numbness of her mind caused by freezing weather. It helps. Occasionally she leaves trail in the snow behind. It helps too. More than once she caught herself on thoughts about warmer apparel. Before she remembers.

Ghost came back to the Traitor. Young girl wished this meeting to be the last.

Catra wanted to take away what betrayer got in exchanged for Catra’s life. It is so unfair that deserter live in the palace with servants. And feline lost everything. But newly-made rebel doesn’t know it, yet. Catra needs her to realize what she has done. Only then vengeance could be satisfying.

Traitor’s legs gave way, she dropped on the floor after girl’s words, crying. Catra had opportunity to end this. Do that she wanted.

Suddenly girl become very aware of that exactly she was planning to do with Adora. Did Catra really was about to..?

Catra don’t trust herself with being near her former friend anymore. She left the room and started to walk.

Now she is at the middle of nowhere. Alone. With her thoughts. Snow whirls in the air.

BOOM

As if. Catra turns in the direction of explosion.

Horde outpost tower over lands around. Claiming this cold wasteland as ground under Horde control. Teasing rebels to come and try to prove otherwise.

Which they are doing. With some success, judging by holes in outer walls and smoking carcasses of unrecognizable machinery. Light blasts regularly flash on battlefield. Garrison stands their ground. Or one of princesses uses her magic.

Loud bang, that invaded feline’s relative peace, was a result of outpost generator’s malfunction. Without it this facility absolutely unsuitable to live. Rebels could fall back now and Horde will leave the place nevertheless.

Catra is watching fight from the distance. Attackers don’t stop until they beat up every single soldier, who couldn’t retreat in capricious weather outside. One good snowfall and it’s possible to scattered garrison squad to get lost in freezing desert. Until cold will take them.

Eventually rebels went away. Bruised losers begun to preparing their leave too.

"*khhr* …there are you?" Distorted voice is coming from shallow cleft near feline. Catra jumped down to examine it. And felt someone alive under thin layer of snow on the bottom. Feline dug out in the source of this feel. Helmeted head appeared from the snow. Not familiar Horde soldier. Unconscious.

"*khr* …have to evacuate." Guy didn't react. Squad won't try to search for him, if soldier don't reply. It is too risky and chances are too low. Catra needs to do something and fast.

She kicked guy in the ribs. Hard. No effect. Feline also can send a signal to his team, then. She brushed off more snow from soldier and examined radio, attached to his armor. It is a miracle that comm can receive anything. Mic is torn off, big crack in its body, wires are exposed.

She searched guy's equipment for stun baton. Soldier don't have it on him. Looking for the weapon in the snow is pointless.

If ghost won't find another solution, she might get a company here. Catra started to worry about this unlucky soldier, other princesses' victim like herself. She leaned over him and made one more attempt to awake him.

"Get up!"

He jumped to his feet. And fell faceplate-first in a snow. Groaning soldier tried to stand up, but failed. He was under snow for too long. Or kick what knocked him out was too strong. No chance for him to reach base alone. And they still have to climb out of the cleft somehow.

Catra tried to pick up soldier herself. He is heavy. She placed her arms below his, embracing soldier from behind. And hovered up. Maybe she'll try more tricks from stories about spirits later.

And guy feels more solid after ghost shouted. Like he is really here, and not phantom as rest of things. Feline isn't even thinking too much about touch to maintain it.

She began walking to outpost once they reached ground level.

"*khr* …up. We are leaving. Sorry." Seriously?

Guy putted hand on radio. Illegible rattle comes from his mouth, but to no avail.

Catra appeared at the outpost. But soldier stayed behind.

She hears noise of skiffs engines from outpost. Welp, it all was for nothing, if his squad left no vehicles behind. Catra will going to check it. However, firstly she needs to get infantry somewhere warm. Feline returned to the guy.

Catra brought soldier inside barracks building and putted him on farthest from the entrance bunk, blankets will help from cold. She threw several at him. Next, Catra picked empty crate from storage room, one stun baton too, and a pallet. Ghost finally adjusted to her situation, so it didn't cause her trouble. Soon a small fire started to radiate heat into the room. Catra waited until soldier become more active. Sense of connection to living being dissipated.

Why she helped him? Good question. Catra never saw as someone die before her eyes. Except herself. Raising number on this counter feels bad. Also, she was mad at rebels. And feline saw relation between her situation and the one this soldier get into.

Rebels didn't kill her. It was the witch. They just took away all other options.

Soldiers from the Rebellion didn't kill this guy. Cold would do it for them. But she saved him.

Catra is having unexpectedly busy afterlife.

Feline went to check if soldier's squad left a skiff in case their squadmate is alive. They did. Against protocols about resources. Soldier won't die. She is not sure, if her old squad would do something like this for her. Adora always stick to the rules, until she doesn't. Things are tensed between Catra and Lonnie. Cadet would left her here. No one in the squad understand Rogellio, so it would be difficult for him to convince others to anything like this. And Kyle simply don't have a spine for it. Huh. Catra had nothing in the Horde even before, hadn't she?

Ghost left wrecked place.

***

Catra seriously pissed off by rebels. They came at the end of the world, broke her solitude, almost killed random grunt and returned back to their luxurious life. Ghost can't escape this dumb war even here.

Well, if they can't leave Catra alone, she will not leave them alone too.

Way to rebels capital is short. Locating target that would help her to make a point took more time. She found one in the palace.

Endless corridors, halls, rooms, mostly empty. One room in particular. Rebel's meeting. They are eating, talking, playing. Some of their conversations about last raid on Horde camp. It was princess' idea. These soldiers as idiotic as their counterparts in the Horde. They are wasting their lives for princess' ambitions. They aren't worth her attention.

Catra peeked in the room again before come in. Old habits die hard. Princess at the table. In blissful ignorance about her past doings and her close future. Rebels think what they are safe there, at home. Catra will make them reconsider.

***

Glimmer decided that success of their quick and completely unauthorized mission in Northern Reach deserve a celebration. Destruction of Plumeria still looming over them, rebels were only a day late to save it. If not for Angella's hesitation a month ago Glimmer could help them. Anyway, now princess has a victory and small celebration to boost the morale. She invited Bow, team of rebels, who went on the mission with them, and Adora, who didn't.

Glimmer hoped what Adora would finally leave her room for the party. She liked the one in Thaymor after all. It is a pipe dream.

Her friend has been spending less and less time with Glimmer and Bow since her first day in Brightmoon. Adora trained with and without sword for a good part of day. Went out of her room only for missions. Princess thought what it was a Horde thing and that she just needs to show Adora that world can be good outside of it.

But after incident in Salineas Adora shut out herself completely from everyone. In sea city her friend from the Horde tried to bring Adora back in Fright Zone. And, apparently, it wasn't her friend, but an illusion what used same appearance. Glimmer still confused by this event. Princess can only guess how Adora feels about it. Because she refuses to talk about it and to leave her room at all.

Party could distract Adora from disarray in the head. Glimmer considered bringing sword wielder at small dining hall, there they are holding celebrations, by force. So Adora might at least talk with other sword fighters, if not with her. Princess just want her friend to get well.

Apart from that, party is good. Warriors is less tensed around Glimmer after they fought side by side. Rebels are telling stories about their own battles. One of them taught her some card game, which Glimmer now playing along with other warrior and Bow.

Dishes from palace kitchen great as always. Reason for their gathering fantastic. They pushed away the Horde. Under her command. And mom thinks what they were visiting Mermista, so Glimmer won't get grounded for it.

Misplaced movement drew princess attention. Barefoot figure in ragged red colored uniform is walking in her direction from the door. Its arms to the elbow black as tar, wild mane have smoldering patches in it, eyes appear to be without whites. She didn't hear doors opening. And other guests are ignoring intruder. Then phantom went through one of the warriors. Glimmer patted Bow on his shoulder.

"Wh…" She began raising hand to point at… somewhat familiar feline before her. With closer look princess noticed almost indistinguishable blood trail on her cloth.

She never finished her gesture. Intruder cut through her chest with sharp claws. Glimmer got caught off guard and didn't has time to teleport.

Force of the strike threw Glimmer on the floor. She felt shift of her cut ribs. And her breath becoming more difficult as blood pour into lung. Princess looked on attack's aftermath. Four long bleeding lacerations. Too low to hit heart. Room fell silent.

Then shock ended. Glimmer felt extreme pain from her wounds.

Bow reacted first.

"Someone, bring a first aid kit!" He bent over and carefully made her sit, tilting on left side.

"And call a healer!" Archer is trying to close wounds with napkin from the table. It is too small. Closest warrior joined his effort.

Door slammed. Glimmer hear receding rapid steps from hallway.

Bow asks her to concentrate on breathing. Her friend is saying soothing, reassuring words. What help will be here soon. What he

is here for her.

Glimmer needs it. She couldn’t even imagine that she would be doing without him there.

Princess’ is looking at the floor, her head lowered. Culprit of current situations keep standing behind rebels, who is trying to undo her action. Glimmer can see only feline’s legs. Blood, what flowing down from somewhere above them, is mixing with her own. Intruder isn’t leaving nor making any attempts to strike again.

Old warrior shouting command to others. Nonsense about windows, corridors, patrols.

“She's right there...” Glimmer wants to tell them, but she fears to lose control over her breath.

Feeling of phantom presence with her on the way to healer house. It lingered until she passed out from medications.

***

Catra did wanted to make the princess pay for what she has done to her. But ghost couldn't bring herself to kill even person she hated so badly. At the last moment Catra redirected her blow.

She followed wounded rebel to the doctor’s house. Feline waited until she was sure what princess will survive. During her field medicine classes, Catra have seen soldiers recovered from more serious injuries in Horde hospital. It will take a whole lot of time, though.

Feline started to leave the place, but that guy with bow still waited outside operating room. He reminds Catra of herself while Adora has been severely sick. However, boy’s worries easier to notice.

From discussions at rebels meeting she get the idea what almost no one truly acknowledged his effort in attack on outpost and the princess' made fun of his dumb arrows. Don't take her wrong, Catra is frustrated by his participation in kidnapping and recent raid. But archer fought fair, without magic.

This is just hit too close to home. Is he realizing what princess is doing to him?

Are they realizing what Adora will do to them? That amused Catra. Princess is too weak in comparison to Adora. So, there is no chance this won't happen. Feline wants to see princess' face when high-born figure out what she is someone sidekick now and not other way around.

Anyway, Catra sees a kindred spirit in this boy. She'll make him doubt, if being near princess is good for him. Catra has been there and look where it got her. Too bad she can't help herself with the same thing. Despite everything, young girl wants to go back to Adora.

Still, ghost needs to think of something to talk with the boy. No normal person would answer to disembodied voice.

Feline notice what archer has another tablet of his. If only she had one on her. Or ghost can just… she stuck her hand inside the device.

"Hey." Text showed on the screen. Tablet rang. Yep, it worked.

"She will be okay, you know." An offering to conciliate him.

Boy picked up the tablet. He has read message, frowned. Pause. Archer typing something back.

"*Thanks for reassuring.*"

"I am searching for the attacker. Can't come in person to you right now. You were with her during the assault, right?" Rebels not the brightest people. Archer can fall for her bluff.

Boy tensed. His fingers begun trembling. *"Yes. But I haven't seen anyone. Glimmer was right beside me, and second later she is on the floor."*

"You can help in another way. You are close with the princess. Why would someone want her dead? Aside Horde, obliviously."

"*Who else if not the Horde done it?*" Catra does not consider herself as Horde member anymore. So, technically, it wasn't the Horde. It is personal.

"You tell me. People doing horrible things for many reasons. Maybe she did something too." A bait. Archer buried his head in his hands for a second. Tablet on his knees. Rebels are so ridiculous.

"Glimmer did nothing to deserve this." Wrong.

"But what if? How would you react?" Catra became bold.

"What kind of question is it?" He said it, not typed. Ghost won't push him more this time.

"Just try to remember what were you both doing for past few months. I am not asking for more. See ya." Possibly he'll manage to understand princess' wrongs before it is too late. Catra pulled out her hand from the device. Screen went blank.

Feline is done here. What she will do next?

As her catatonic state ended, Catra needs something to spend her time.

She may try to find out where Horde putted her mortal remains. Starting from there feline arrived to rebel's city seems like a good idea.

***

Disaster wrested Adora from her slumber. She was the third person outside the hall, who learned about incident with Glimmer. First was the doctor. Second was Queen. Exhausted messenger looked at her with such hope. Like Adora can fix it instantly. Heal the princess and find out who responsible for hurting her in the blink of an eye.

But she cannot. Sword doesn't response to her at all since Adora returned from Salineas. And soldier wasn't sure if she wanted to use it. Scene of illusory Catra dissolving under swings of Adora's weapon haunt her. She doesn't know what would happen to her, if Shadow Weaver will use another illusion like this. But previous time in Brightmoon was much worse.

Now Adora must get sword to work. She has to make good on her promise to Queen. Soldier went where she needed.

Inside Glimmer's ward only Angella met her, princess is sleeping. Queen is sitting near the bed. Her hand hold Glimmer's. Bow gave mother some private time with daughter.

"How this could happen?" Angella broke silence.

"Whispering Woods always protected us from malicious people. Why it let someone through now?" Another futile question.

"If we are not safe even here, what can I do to protect her?" Adora can't keep standing here and do nothing any longer.

"Your Majesty, sorry to interrupt, but I know what She-Ra supposed to have healing power. Please, allow me to use it." Queen turned her eyes from Glimmer to Adora.

"Are you sure you can do it?" Angella said firmly. She wants to be certain, that Adora won't make it worse.

"I am not. But I have to try." It is her fault. Adora wasn't with Glimmer when this happened.

The sword didn't react to her pledge.

She has let them down again. Adora can’t transform into She-Ra.

“I believe you tried your best.” Her best isn’t enough. She needs to be better.

“You can stay, if you want.” Adora must to fix it. Sitting here won’t help her friend.

She-Ra will. Adora should regain control on the sword. She has to know more about the blade. Angella wasn’t very helpful with it, despite what Bow said.

Then Adora can take knowledge from First One’s themselves. She got a feeling, that Razz showed her ruins for a reason. Soldier will find this beacon again.

***[1]

Catra wandered through the Woods around Brightmoon. But trees have moved long time ago. No hints of the place, where she first time become aware in her current state.

That is why feline noticed as lone deserter walked out of the city. It’s like they destined to gravitating to each other. And she is tired going against the tide. Catra followed Adora deeper into the Woods. Ghost walks alongside with her, unseen.

Blondie is looking for something. Whatever it is, she got no better results than feline. They spent a lot of time walking in circles. Light is fading and so Adora’s aspiration. When her former friend stopped and started to crumble, Catra appeared in her sight, slightly away from deserter.

“No.” Adora spoke in feeble voice. She closed her eyes. “You are not here.”

“I am not.” Her body lies somewhere between here and lifeless lands on the west.

“But do you want me to be?” Catra herself wants.

“You would never believe how much.” Adora is right. Ghost won’t believe until blondie says the words.

“Then you can pretend what I am.” And Catra will keep her part of agreement regardless if Adora is lying or not.

“This wouldn’t be real.” Too late for it to be real for both of them.

“That the difference?” For Catra it still would be one-sided promise, and for Adora she still would be just out of reach.

“You were different in Salineas.” Magic crap. It magic, that is ruining Catra and other people around her.

“I never was there.”

“I mean, it was an illusion. Fake you said what she will be anything I want, if I’ll go back in the Horde with her.” Adora decided to bring this up now. Damn, for how long she kept it to herself?

“True you would never said this.” Catra ready to sacrifice a lot of things to be with Adora, if her feeling is mutual. But what illusion offered beyond her every limit.

“After I refused, she pounced on me.” Feline would…

“And I accidentally impaled her with the sword.” Ah. Catra see it now. Adora feels guilty for killing illusion of the friend by her own hands.

“It wasn’t me.” Blondie has enough real things to feel guilty about. Blondie exhaled.

“But I’m still dead and your leaving has done this.” Catra isn’t dead for good, but it isn’t less frustrating.

“Then why you are here?” Catra is hurt more without Adora than with her.

“I told you.”

“And vanished after.” If ghost didn’t, her friend wouldn’t be here. And, maybe, alive.

“Because you didn’t answer.” It was the source of most Catra’s anger.

“Do you want to know it now?” She needs to know it.

“A little too late for me. But go ahead.”

“I love you too.” Finally. Catra would give everything to hear these words earlier. But she has nothing.

Except Adora. Probably.

Ghost stretches her arms out to sides. They hugged before. Back when friends were kids. Very rare signs of affection and therefore more appreciated. Adora have to come to her for once.

She hesitated for a moment. Next, Adora made a step in her direction. Run to her, after. And tackled Catra to the ground in embrace.

Adora’s face surprised. She wasn’t sure if it’s true. Pair stayed like this for a while.

Blondie moved slightly.

“I went in Whispering Woods for a reason.” Why can’t she just be happy?

“Glimmer is hurt and I couldn’t feel She-Ra anymore. Now she is back. I have to go back and heal my friend.” Catra flinched. Adora felt it. All good things come to an end.

“Wait.” Blondie haven’t realized this before. Sense of comfort left them both.

“Wait. Wait! Wait!” Adora recoiled back.

“You did that!”

“Why it always like this with you?!” Like it is Catra got Adora killed.

“Princess made you leave! It is her fault I am like this!” Catra pointed at features that giving out her undead state.

“I left because the Horde is doing horrible things! I would go away in any case!” Adora freeze. Implication of these words reached her brain after she said them.

“No! I didn't mean it like that!” They screamed up to this moment, but Adora’s shout should be heard by everyone who was unlucky enough to spend the night in the Woods.

“I wanted you to come with me! I would return for you in Fright Zone, if I led the attack to Thaymur.”

“It doesn’t matter. What are you going to do now is.” Catra’s tone is low. Just a few months ago feline wouldn’t imagine what Adora can choose princess over her. It is likely outcome today.

Silence. Adora is thinking.

“I’m going to find First One’s ruins deep in Whispering Woods. Please, give me time.”

Their stroll continued. Catra stays out of view. Adora didn’t asked to help with her search.

Eventually, her, perhaps, friend walked in the clearing with big structure at its center.

Then Adora turned to the Woods and yelled:

“Are you there?!”

Ghost poked blondie in the shoulder with a claw. Without making herself visible.

“Ouch. I just wanted you to wait for me here. I will be back.”

“I...” Adora trailed off. And went to the ruins.

Calm

Chapter Notes

[2]Storm - Paperwhite

If to think about it, Catra have spent a lot of her time lately waiting for something or walking around aimlessly. She just itches for consistent goal.

Feline considered going inside. But since her failed attempt to affect trapdoor with new ghost ability, Catra had a bad feeling about it. So, currently ghost is sitting on the top of ruins. Moon lonely traveling in the sky.

She felt a sudden touch on her arm.

“Catra?”

Ghost dozed off. Which is bad as she didn’t feel any fatigue. Is this happened before without her noticing?

“What?!” She shouted.

Adora is standing at Catra’s side. Blondie quickly retracted her arm after contact. Feline noticed what stains she left on blouse and jacket during their embrace fully dried up. Catra was out of it for a while, then.

“I called for you from the ground, but you didn’t respond. I had to climb all the way up here. Are you…”

“You asked for a time. You have it. Answer. Who do you choose?” Her lag very disturbing. What Adora found Catra like this making it worse.

Blondie’s countenance grew serious. **[2]**

“I wasn’t going to choose Glimmer over you. I will not lose you again.” There is a but.

“But we can’t ignore that happened.” On ghost glare Adora continued. “With both of you.”

“So, that do you suggest? To talk it out? Like “hey killing you was a bad thing to do” and “assassination attempt wasn’t nice either” or what?”

“I don’t know.” Adora didn’t reacted on her snap. She stayed composed.

“Yet. I want you to come with me and figure it out.” Adora *wants* Catra around her. Blondie doesn’t “have to” make feline follow her because “it's right thing to do”. She needs it herself.

“Eh. Won’t hurt to try. For me, at least.” Feline’s momentary anger ebbed away. Her lag isn't a thing she wants someone to know about. But Adora seems to think that Catra made her to get in there on purpose. No more concern on blondie’s face like at the beginning of conversation. Only confidence in her decision.

“Good.” Adora made a pause, like she expected Catra to say something. But she knows that sense of control is important for her best friend. Feline will go along. Within reasonable limits.

“I have no idea where to start. Last time I was in similar situation, I tried to punch a Horde camp single-handedly. Got hit by a canon, by the way.” Adora continued. This sounds very in her style.

“Want to do it again?” Destroying things is fun. Need to think of something to deal with the soldiers, though.

“Except cannon part. Have any better suggestions?”

“No. Let’s go then.” Catra hopes what where would be no extreme temperatures, or high mountains, or big water bodies around the place Adora decided to wreck.

Ghost hovered to the ground. Catra let blondie take a lead when she climbed down.

Duo’s journey through the Wood is bringing them closer and closer to Fright Zone. Adora tell ghost to get above crowns from time to time and check if they went astray. Catra was thinking what Horde territory should have been to the west from the ruins. But friends walking to big deserted patch on the south.

“A bit late, but I haven’t lost my mind, right?” Adora said out of blue.

“Sane person wouldn’t ask this.” Or confess in love to phantom.

“I mean, Light Hope told me, that ghosts do not exist.”

“Not every day someone trying to persuade you, that you aren’t existing.”

“Please, say what you are not my hallucination.” Adora stopped and looked in Catra’s face.

“You are not my hallucination” She can’t help it.

“Ha-ha.” Adora made posed laughter. “So, you are truly here and a ghost like Weeping...”

“Don’t you dare to end this sentience. Or I will haunt you for the rest of your life”

“Don't threaten me with a good time.”

Both of them starts chuckling.

“Oh, we really are insane.” Catra said after laughter died down. “Anyway, who is Light Hope?”

“She is a hologram from the ruins of temple. Light Hope knows a lot of things about She-ra’s powers, but she refuses to explain

them to me, unless I'll stay inside for decades of years and train with her."

"Hologram is the one to talk about ghosts." Forgotten machinery of extinct race and dead feline, who only wanted by one person. Their situation not very different.

"I asked her about healing power. And if I can use it to bring you back to life. That is when Light Hope told what there is no ghosts. You think she'll change her mind, if you come with me next time?"

"I tried to open the trapdoor back there. It resisted, not just ignored me. I think she was lying to you."

Feline have things to proceed. And blondie too. Is there a way back for Catra? Too good to be true. But a chance for Adora to be hers, and be Adora's in return for real... She would do anything for it.

This is first time they get to talk with each other without something blowing up in their faces. Naturally, pair resumed conversation later.

"What is the deal with your look? You were just like before when we first met in the city."

"I didn't give it much a through. These things just show up and go away, as they please." Not a whole truth. Catra *wanted* Adora to see what happened to her back there. But some marks really had disappeared on their own after.

"And what about cloth? Is it a part of your body? Can you control it?" Feline had no reason to experiment with it yet. Does blondie have something on her mind?

"What for?"

"In case you would want to change it." Adora abashed. Weirdo.

“You think I can magically change how do I look?” Catra went up to check the path.

“You are magic now.” Adora said as ghost returned from her scouting in the sky.

“Nope, flying is natural for my species. I just didn’t want to do it before, so you could get a possibility to win in sparring.” Catra don’t hate magic itself. It just happens what all magic users she knows are arrogant, snobbish jerks. And straight up hate her, well, with one exception.

She made Adora giggle a little.

“I would take you in a fight even with flying.” Like she could do it in her normal state.

“Save it for poor soldiers we are going to beat up” Feline already feel pity for them. Kind of.

“Are you scared?” Adora wants a challenge. So be it. When they will be done with more urgent problem.

“Me? Never.”

Quipping with her best friend went in its usual course. Maybe rebels have fancy word for bounds between them. But Catra know what they are as is.

Clearings become more frequent as pair coming closer to their destination point. Trees have less foliage. Ground is free from grass. Gargantuan withered tree down the road.

“Horde poisoned Plumeria. We couldn’t do anything, and tribe what lived there didn’t even wanted to defend themselves. They believed, that She-Ra could save them from any threat.” Catra would give that passive idiots piece of her mind.

“Too bad for them, you can’t save people from their own stupidity.” Adora weirdly looked at her. Ah. Right.

Catra stopped her friend, took blondie’s arms in hers and met Adora’s eyes. She knows that happened, but not the reason behind it.

“After the village I was sure what you threw away your whole life for some rebels, what I'm worth nothing for you, what everything we had didn’t mattered anything for you.” Catra still have vanishingly small doubts, if it true. “I was ready to die, to get rid of this feeling.”

“Sorry…” Useless word. Unlike what Adora said before she found the ruins.

“But I’m glad what I was wrong.” Ghost interrupted blondie. It has to stay in the past. Or they will have no future at all.

[2] End]

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Big tree occurs to have abandoned Horde woodcutting equipment around it. And stone alike one in Brightmoon inside the trunk. But this magic rock is inert. Traces of long-lasted camp is present on the clearing too. Fire pits, compost piles near tree line, broken little trinkets in the dirt.

“Perfuma went missing a few weeks ago. Refugees said, that she was visiting her runestone to try make it work again. I want to search for her, while we are here.” Horde don’t disappear by itself. If soldiers left tools, something drove them away. It may be a princess doing. Or not.

Adora already went to the tree in the center. Catra groaned and followed her. This is same kind of idiocy they talked about just now. Looking for a person in the dark isn’t a good idea, especially in enemy territory.

So, it was surprising what Adora actually found one. Figure is sitting on the ground underneath the tree’s stone.

“Hello.” She just done this. Is being a rebel damaging brain?

“...” Stranger says something, but it is too quiet, even for Catra, and her hearing stayed the way as before. She also not almost blind in the dark in contrast to Adora. And Catra doesn’t like how the other ghost looks. Lighting marks very familiar to her. Feline has them herself. She needs to get Adora out of here.

Catra grabbed her friend by the back of the jacket collar and began to dragging rebel away from phantom. Adora is trying to break out her grasp.

“Oh, no. We are not going to mess around the person, who was recently electrocuted to death.” Catra’s reaction was bad. Who knows what this ghost could do. Adora let feline to carry her to the edge of forest.

“Care to elaborate?” Blondie said as she got to her feet.

“Whoever it was, now it wouldn’t be happy to see anyone. Talking from experience. We better leave this place.” Catra may or may not return here later. Alone.

Expression on Adora’s face fell.

“Horde camp is not far from here, come on.”

***

It is close to moonrise when pair reached their destination. This time they agreed to observe target from high point first. Adora climbed dead tree. Catra appeared on the branch close to her. It is standard Horde camp. Duo can navigate in there with their eyes closed. Numbers of personal more interesting. Which is too high for completed operation. Horde preparing an attack for next objective, most likely.

“Any more advise, mighty rebel captain?” Adora teased her. They are distracting themselves from recent encounter.

“I’m not with rebels, and yes.” Catra planned this as one-time thing. Ideally, she would make her friend to move away from the war. Go with her and forget about it. But if war found ghost in barren icy desert, it can catch up with them anywhere.

“Don’t tell me what you are still with the Horde.”

“I on my own side. Want to join? I am planning to overthrow all princesses and take over the Horde after. I’ll gratefully let you chose a territory to govern.” Their old dream. Catra now as far away from it as possible. But for Adora it started to look achievable. Catra would help her to get it. Blondie just needs to say the word.

“Joke aside, you said it went bad last time, I’ll do a recon and then we make a plan to destroy the camp.” Back to business.

“This make sense. Okay.” Their first mission together isn’t like Catra imagined it.

She went to the group of buildings.

Armory is her first stop. Need to check if they have enough explosions to blow up the facility after fight. Catra found it fully stacked with armor. If it all here, then at least a battalion quartered in there. Without combat equipment, yet. Feline remember what She-Ra did in Thaymor. Massacre, that it will be in case Adora break into the camp.

Change of plans. Catra will deal with garrison herself. She took some grenades and fuses from the stash. It will slow her down. Things refuses to go through the walls with her.

She placed first explosive near fire sensor in this very room and set a timer on it. Doors automatically blocks during fire-fighting system work. Next, feline slashed a small hole in the wall to retrieve grenades.

Second stop is tank’s parking zone. Catra shoved rest of explosives inside barrels. Without access to weaponry and vehicles

soldiers will have no other choice but to retreat. Ghost have one more idea how to make it happen for sure.

She went to mess hall. Day shift receiving their rations now. A line of soldier in regular outfit is waiting for their turn to get a bar with indescribable taste. Several of them talking. One conversation got Catra's attention.

"You heard about that guy from north outpost?"

"Yeah, crazy man telling stories about some creature from permafrost that brought him back to base after he fell in the crest and disappeared without a trace after."

"You think he is lying? I mean, our enemies literally have magic."

"This is the reason I think what rebels just kicked him in the head too hard. Why would one of them help Horde soldier?"

"Maybe you are right."

Just a story, huh? Let's see if they like it themselves. Catra tested how much she could manipulate in power greed. A small distortion for a start. Apparently, all she can see. Catra waited for timers she set. Half a minute before it, she passionately swiped the wall with her claws, leaving deep gashes. Loud screech filled the hall. Soldiers shut up and turned in her direction.

Ghost turned off wall lights. There are surprised voices. Screens, on the other hand, begun to display "Run away" text on max brightness. Soldiers' attention focused on them with general lighting disabled. Spikers gave off the most devastating death rattle Catra could ever vocalize. This is overkill. She just wanted to try it.

Then bombs go off.

Someone panicked and screamed. It is enough to annihilate any discipline soldiers had left. Officers can't restore order fast, because no one sees them, and their commands drowning in

noise from speakers. Soldiers proximity to each other in line worked in Catra's favor. When first started to move purposefully to the outside, the rest troops followed them. Ghost opened several doors on opposite sides of the hall. Others exits stayed closed despite soldiers tries to open them. Catra is dispersing squads. So, it takes them longer to recover. Feline hovered to the roof of building, to observe the chaos she created.

People running around in disarray. Officers is trying to shout commands to deal with fires. Catra hopes what Adora figures out it was a signal for her to arrive.

Rebellion hero come in sight from behind dead trees line, already in She-Ra form. Panic had enough time to spread from day shift to the whole camp. If garrison was scared from ghost's improvisation, then after they noticed She-Ra soldiers become freaking terrified. Camp emptied very fast.

"And what happened with "I'll do a recon"?" Adora isn't upset. Maybe only a little.

"Allow me to report, oh, my commander. Recon of enemy positions showed what there is no enemy to recon" Catra made a caricature salute. Retaliation on Adora's earlier tease. "Besides, you still have a whole facility to wreak."

"Going to leave me all hard work?" Blondie like beating things up. They are just joking.

"Nah, I'll check if I can take one of tanks. And we'll see who can destroy more Horde property." Catra grinned. She had left some of vehicles intact on that purpose.

Catra decided to drive armored vehicle in traditional way. Poor vision from inside compensated by feel of normality. She checked powercells, scope and controls. Feline don't want to miss the fun because of it. All good. The tank should be operated by a crew, but it heavily automatized, so a single person can manage it too. Catra did before.

Feline started to demolish her part of camp without warning. She made sure that Adora nowhere near lesion area before shoot, though.

Two-story barracks is a good target. Its walls aren't hardened and teared down easily by canon shots. Load-bearing supports gave in soon, too. Building have sufficient number of flammable things inside to catch on fire. Barracks went down in flames.

Next, Catra drove her tank straight through the group of small service facilities. They are made from light plates on quickly erectable frames and didn't slowed down armored vehicle even a little. Facilities collapsed on the ground behind her.

Tearing up the communication tower part by part is enjoyable. Chunks of metal construction flying away in different directions. Feline left only bits near foundation. Destroying it properly would take inordinate amounts of time.

Well, it was fun. Competition was a game, not serious thing. Pair didn't count any points. Only bragged, that they do better than opponent. Duo left armory for last, as it is full of highly dangerous materials. Adora and feline in tank got to a safe distance, before Catra finally made a shot straight in it. Explosion is BIG and satisfying.

Horde would need to build it all over again, if they want to use this ground.

"Soooo, why we were doing it?" Whatever it is, they'll deal with it.

"I wanted to figure out how can you stay with me in Brightmoon. I think if we do something like this with Glimmer and Bow, it would help. What do you think?" Catra can tolerate rebels, if Adora asks her. Occasionally.

"Okay. But we are taking the tank with us." Catra is sure what rebels don't have cool stuff like this.

***

Their arrival to Rebellion capital drew attention, small crowd gathered across the river. Great She-ra walked out of the Woods holding Horde tank above her head. Catra stands on the top of it, unknowingly for ordinary mortals.

"You could drive it in here, you know." Adora behave as if she doesn't like an opportunity to show off.

"It would be better to save powercells for later. We didn't take replacements before blowing up the place. And I haven't heard what rebels is using captured Horde machinery. It is doubtful they got something like this." Feline got distracted and simply forgot to bring backup batteries with her.

"I am not going to haul it inside the city. Rebels don't have hangars for vehicles. And tank will scare people, if they see it on the streets." Maybe rebels will like battle vehicle more, when they paint it in purple. This image made Catra shiver. No, she won't let princess' minions vandalize her tank.

"Just put it down there then. We'll make a shelter for it when got time." After Adora lowered armored vehicle on the ground, she let go of She-Ra form. Is blondie have limit for how long she can use it?

"Where we are going next?"

"I need to see Glimmer. She was hurt pretty bad, when I left." Catra was pretty hurt when Adora left. It isn't hatred, only distant irritation, it'll fully disappear, just not yet.

"Should I go with you?" Feline don't want to see princess, if she can avoid it.

"You can wait outside."

"I will."

On the way to doctor house, Catra looked on the city for real. Not as possible target with weak points and preferable attack angles, but as a place where people live, work, have fun. Not in her style. Still better than Fright Zone. Citizens sharing houses by small groups, not by dozens. Buildings themselves got a space around them. Unlike Horde supercomplex what stretches for kilometers. Some structures don't have useful function on the first look. Like big pool full of water, in another open space friends are passing by, could be for washing, but as no one tried to do so, it may be a part of cooling system. Catra couldn't imagine that so much space and resources were spent for nothing. Also, trees inside the city have artificial shapes without any reason. And everything made out of stones, not concrete. Feline can get used to it after some time.

Pair came to familiar house. Adora went to princess' ward.

***

Door closed behind Adora. Glimmer still rests in the bed. Bow is sitting close to princess. They were quietly talking about something. Hero's arrival made them turn to her.

"Adora! Where have you been?" They shouted in unison. Princess more like said it than shouted.

"Uh. Hi, guys." Adora haven't prepared for this conversation. Her thoughts were focused on different topic.

"We were worry sick about you." Bow talk for Glimmer too.

"I was in Whispering Wood. First One's built whole underground temple for She-Ra in there. I tried to learn how to use her healing power. It didn't work." And Adora got even more problems on her hands. Good kind of problem, but nonetheless. Situation with Catra is a thing she have to fix.

"You can't disappear for days without saying anything, what if something happened to you?" Adora felt a little guilty for spending

about a week underground. But her first best friend reacted normal. Well, at least in a way that is count normal for Catra. Soldier thought what rebels won't be weird about it too.

"Hologram inside the temple didn't wanted me to leave. It took time to make an agreement. I'll warn you in advance next time." And she had things to think about. Destruction of countless bots helped.

"You look nervous. Is there something else?" Bow is a person, who tries to make people talk about their problems. Adora can only wish to know what answer to him will help her make things right.

"I found who attacked Glimmer. This won't happen again. I'll tell you details, when you get better. It is complicate." Adora have no idea how to introduce Catra to rebels. For now, she just reassures her friends, what their home is safe.

Glimmer and Bow eased up.

"I suppose you went right in here when returned? I have to send a message to Angella, then." Bow said and leaved the room. Is Adora interrupted something?

They talked about nothing in particular after it. Glimmer tried to find out that Adora is hiding, but she evaded the questions.

***

Catra stayed in the hall. Guy, that had bow on him during their last meeting, soon exited from Glimmer's room and joined her. Seems like blondie decided to wait before introducing ghost to her new friends.

Catra will try to know, if boy did introspection, while she was gone.

"Hey." His tablet rang once again.

"I guess the great She-Ra figured out princess' case." Guy quickly took device in hands.

"How do you know?"

"I have my ways. Sadly, I'm busy with my problem away from here. But I'm still curious, if you got ideas what Glimmer could have done to piss off someone to this degree." Catra isn't trying hard to come up with some answer. Boy is too gullible.

"Not any. She is a little too much from time to time. But Glimmer would never done something so wrong to get this as fair response." Progress. Very slow, yet it is there.

"But what if you are wrong about her? Who will you be without the princess?" Guy went pale. Catra has gone too far, most likely. Or she found something. This is food for thought.

"Never mind. Can you get her a tablet when she wakes up? About the same time?" Feline can accelerate things, if she pushes from both sides.

"She is awake." Strange. Do they have healing magic besides She-Ra's? It's only been a day.

"Well, tomorrow will work fine. See ya." Boy didn't agree. But he looks malleable enough to do it anyway.

Feline didn't have to wait Adora for long. Soon pair is strolling through the streets of Brightmoon.

"Have more plans for today?" Catra doesn't.

"Actually, I am heading to my room. It has been quite a day."

"Meh, I'll find something to do." City is big and mostly unexplored. Just watching how people live in here could be entertaining.

Adora paused.

“Want to come with me?”

Maybe things finally started to look up for Catra.

Calm. Bonus scene.

Chapter Notes

Interlude. Intimacy. Skippable.
[3] t.A.T.u. - A Simple Motion

Adora's room mostly stayed the same. Blondie only putted away rebel's garbage to one side of it, and made small training area in another. Also, bed, on which they are currently sitting, got unstabbed mattress.

"Are you up for some experiments?" Is it what Catra thinks?

"I mean, what you can do now, what have you already tried from these scary stories?" Aww.

"Not much. Everything feels normal as long I don't give it much of thought. And I would like it to stay this way."

Adora touched her charred hand.

"If you learn how to control this, you may get better." Or make it worse.

"Please, try it for me."

"Fine."

Feline tried to focus on the marks. She doesn't want them. Adora wants her to not have them. Catra slowly remembered what she was before.

Blackness started to disappear from her limbs. Bleeding from gash stopped, and wound itself closed. Smoldering patches absorbed by regrown mane. At last color returned to mismatched eyes.

Catra needs to check something. She took her tail in hands. Yep, delicate spot from old burn on the end of it stayed. It reassured

Catra. Feline is still herself despite everything. She heavily exhaled and laid on the back. **[3]**

“Thank you.” Blondie leaned over her. Adora’s face get closer until touched hers. They kissed.

Cadets in the Horde had things like this. In general. Future soldiers knew that love is, and what people have specific kind of desires. There just were no reasons to discuss it when true privacy doesn’t exist. Everybody knows all about everyone.

Catra reached for the straps of her jumpsuit. It come off easily, leaving her chest covered only by top. Blondie get the idea what her friend wants. Adora started to remove her jacket. Blouse went after it.

Feline slipped from the rest of suit and kicked it away. It ceases to exist midair. Great. Her friend stands near the bed, she is getting rid of the boots and didn’t noticed it. That's good.

Catra is considering taking off headguard. But if blondie is going to keep her poof, then headgear stays too. Adora is done with pants and belt. Which is leaving them both in underwear.

“How do we do it?” Having general knowledge is not the same thing as full understanding. Pair just feel urge to be close to each other. And when finally, nobody looking behind their backs, pair confused what exactly they have missed because of fear to ask.

“Come here. We’ll figure it out.” Catra took Adora’s hand in hers and pulled friend to the bed. Blondie fell on the top of her. Their heads close again. Their lips touched.

Adora still not close enough to her. Feline took partner’s bra and pulled it upward, revealing her bust. Blondie returned the action.

“You really soft under all of these.” Adora laid head on her chest.

“You are soft.” Catra slapped blondie slightly with tail. She leaned back a little.

“Hey!” Blondie begun stripping feline out of boxers.

“I thought you wanted this.” And feline is completely naked before her friend.

“I do, it was just surprising.” Maybe they actually talk about it before next time.

Adora putted her hand between feline’s legs. Proximity they craving for. She looked at her. Catra nodded. Blondie entered.

Girl didn’t know what to expect. Feel is overwhelming at first. Adora kept moving, but slowed down. Pleasure is growing stronger. Now it smoothly begins feel better, unlike rapid hits of sensation from the start. Blondie is trying to find right tempo. Her movement fastened. Catra let her lead.

She felt as Adora’s touches pushing her closer and closer. Such intimacy is the thing she wanted for so long. A part of what feline wanted.

Sensation hit the peak. And went higher. Catra trembled, feel linger for some time and begun to fading. She recovered quickly.

“My turn now.” Feline brought her friend down on the bed. Blondie’s underwear flied far away. She was talking about experimenting?

Catra kissed Adora. And led her tongue from mouth to the neck, lower, through chest, even more, across the belly. Catra reached the place. She pushed blondie’s legs to the sides with elbows. Girl waited for Adora to give her a sign.

“Go ahead.”

Feline licked. Her friend jerked. Catra looked at her questioningly.

“Your tongue feels weird.” Whoops. Awkward.

“Then I can do the same thing.”

“No. I want to try.”

Girl went down again. Gentler. She is attempting to replicate what blondie did. When feline felt what Adora became more pliable, she tried to go inside. Her friend gasped. It easier to move the more time Catra worked out. Adora grabbed her hairs. Her grasp is tight. Feline went faster.

Blondie flinched and let go of her. A few seconds later she exhaled. Seems like Adora was holding her breath. Feline laid on the top of her friend after she came back to normal.

“It is a big bed. You could lay beside me.”

“Nah, you are too comfy.”

Catra needs to deal with her cloth. But it can wait. World can wait. She putted her ear next to Adora’s chest. Moonlight subsided as feline listened to her heartbeat. Night has come. Dreams do not.

Young girl has a connection to her friend. Apart from feelings and physical contact. Like something is tugging Catra closer even when she presses against Adora. She’ll tell her about it in the morning.

Before

Life is normal. Drills, lessons, exams. Some free time if it all was done faster than it should. Time just for us. Scrapyard got various kinds of things. Findings were interesting enough to keep searching for them. Today is extremely lucky.

“Hey, Adora, looks like someone threw away not completely broken stun baton!” I pulled out damaged weapon from the latest pile of rubbish. They didn’t even remove battery!

“Catra, powercell can be unstable. You better leave it here.” Blondie head rose above another pile. Blah-blah, common sense.

“So, are you saying what you are refusing to take a few shots and I can have all the fun by myself?” Cadets don’t have access to soldiers’ weapon. We will start training with it after graduating. But I can use a trial run.

“No way!” Knew it.

We quickly gathered a number of suitable targets for shooting practice and placed them on armor plate from transporter, that someone before us lifted on a bunch of concrete blocks.

“I found it. My turn first.” Adora do not protests.

I carefully aimed and shoot. Miss. This thing is defective. Like, for real, but it should have hit. I silently handed over the baton to my friend. She pointed weapon higher than junk-target is, compensating deviation of last projectile. And miss. Shot went sideway, baton is too broken. A shame.

Adora returned weapon to me. Shooting itself still fun. I took useless aim again and clicked on the button. Muzzle of the baton exploded. I instinctively closed eyes for a second. Loud bang deafened me. I released my grip on baton and putted hands over my ears. A few shards scratched me, but malfunction weapon blow up in opposite direction.

"..!" Adora is opening her mouth. She is saying something I can't hear.

"I am fine." Hearing slowly returning.

"…re you sure?" Device on her belt started beeping. Signal for upcoming curfew.

"Go. I just need a minute. I'll catch up" My friend worryingly looked at me for the last time and went to our barracks.

Coming into senses took more time than I though. Conversation with commanding officer will be hard.

***

I am angering her on purpose. It can't turn out good for me anyway. No point in obedience.

"...she defected and I'm starting to think she have the right idea. So, maybe it's you who should be showing more respect to me." Defiance until the end.

"Lies!" Lights on the wall exploded one by one. Barracks plunged into darkness. But it doesn't prevent me from seeing as solid shadows closing in.

"I have no more patience to deal with you."

"You failed and you will suffer the consequences."

I feel her magic wrapping around me. My arms and legs are held tightly. Not even slim chance to escape this time. But grasp isn't strong enough to suffocate. Yet.

Witch dragged me outside the room. Where are we heading? She hasn't hesitated with punishments when really wanted it. Labyrinth of corridors can lead anywhere. With each passed turn the list of possible destination points is shortening.

We stopped before entrance to Black Garnet chamber. Shadow Weaver is planning something very nasty, if she decided to make it near her source of power.

Door went up. Witch threw me inside, slammed against runestone, pinned to it with black tendrils. Weak jolts of electricity came from the surface of magic stone, striking through cloth.

"If you can't do anything. I have no more use for you." So, that is how it ends.

This fear was with me for the most part of my life. Sometimes it has been a distance thing, only a memory. Sometimes it has been a vivid threat. Fear is penetrating skin and bones underneath during these moments, crushing will, telling what everything I have done was for nothing.

I have clung to the only person who could delay it. Now she is gone. And the witch is going to do better job on promises than her. No one can save me.

But… do I want it at all?

First lighting came from Shadow Weaver's palm. It tore fabric of my suit, charred hairs under it and left a burn. She didn't fully paralyze me. I cry.

Why should I suppress my screams? For who? It doesn't matter for me. To spite the witch? She doesn't care. And sounds will stay in the room.

Second bolt hit the arm leaving big black spot and group of smaller ones around it. Shadow Weaver is making them stronger.

Third jolt is drawn by material of headguard. It instantly became burning hot. Scalding metal is damaging muscles on my face, disrupting another cry. Stray threads of magic grazed the mane. It hurt badly at the point of contact. But it not as much as main brunt.

I am twitching my head, trying to drop the mask. Sudden pain came from the neck. Sharp runestone' edge cut into it. Warm liquid is leaking down. Staining uniform, floor and magic stone itself.

Witch' white eyes narrowed. She drew nearer and putted one hand on the runestone. Other on my sternum. Electricity came from the Garnet and Weaver' palm in the same time. I can't move. Vision, already blurred with tears, vanished with noticeable hits of shock. Sensation is fading. But magic is going deeper inside my body. It is pulling me away.

I fell.

***

Adora's breath fastened. She started to trashing in the bed. Her friend always was relentless sleeper.

"Adora." Catra tapped her on the forehead. Blondie kept kicking air. Extreme measures, then. Feline pushed her friend from the bed. Adora dropped on the floor and woke up with loud shout.

"That bad?" It's rare. Yet a few times pair went to their training sessions drowsy from restless night. Grey eyes focused on Catra. Blondie pounced on her, embracing feline tightly.

"Whoah!" She didn't behave like this back in the Horde. Adora's breathe slowly evened.

"I saw it. What Shadow Weaver have done to you." Blondie whispered in her ear.

"It's just nightmare." Should be.

"Dream was too real."

"You are imagining things. I told you that happened, and your dumb brain choose tonight to poke fun at you." Or is it because of

their connection? Then, Catra needs her friend rational and well-rested even more.

“Maybe?”

“Yes. Now go back to bed or you will be tired all day.”

“I can’t sleep.” Of course, this would be too easy.

“I’ll go for a walk.” Adora looked at her expectantly.

“Okay. I’ll go with you.” Blondie stood up and started dressing.

“Uh, and where is yours…” She noticed.

“Gone. I don’t know how this works.” Why afterlife can’t be less irritating about common things? Catra went to the doors.

“You aren’t going to walk around like this.”

“No one sees, so what the problem?” Feline don’t regret the reason why she ended up bare, but plain stupidity of situation annoyed her enough to seriously give a thought for a second about going out as is.

“Please don’t. You can take my cloth.” How this supposed to help?

“Yeah, people will not freak out about flying Horde uniform, but invisible ghost would be disturbing for them.”

“Then try your thing again. It worked yesterday.”

“Fine.” As much as Catra didn’t wanted to get used for her state when there is chance to reverse it, but Adora has a point. She needs something to wear. So, magic. Power to change your look at will is… pretty useless, except in current mischief with social taboo and her prude friend.

Her old suit would do. Nothing fancy. Ghost get a handle on this. Red apparel appeared on her. And marks too. Damn it. Adora winced, but left it uncommented.

Pair exited the room. Corridors are mostly empty. Rare guards patrolling hallways. Glowing stones are unlit. And… boy with arrows is sneaking from the palace. Catra spotted him first.

“Seems like we are not the only insomniacs tonight.”

“Let him be.”

“This is literally the most suspicious way to walk I have ever seen. No way, boy is hiding something. Also, aren’t you curios yourself?”

Adora sighed. But still went after boy.

***

Guy occurs to be very easy to follow. He didn’t try to cover his tracks. Pair watched from underbrush as Bow approached large building in the middle of the Woods and knocked to its door. Answer came short after. Door opened. Tall man appeared behind it.

“Bow! I got your message, but why all of a sudden..?”

“Hello, dad. Can we come in first?”

They both entered place.

“Got any idea what he is up to?” Catra walk closer to entrance.

“Bow didn’t say that he has someone outside Brightmoon.” So, no.

Ghost pulled doorknob. Locked. She reluctantly shoved her head and arm through the doors and opened it from the inside.

“Natural ability too?” Adora smirked.

“I thought you wouldn’t like to stay here.” Catra shrugs.

Pair heard voices from the left side.

"…you armed?" It is the tall one. Friends went to investigate more.

"Sit. I need to tell you something. Is George home?"

"No. He went to nearby village for supplies and didn't come back yet."

"Maybe it's for the best." Feline looked around wide room. Books and scrolls on wooden shelves, glass containers with garbage, metallic sphere on far end of the place.

"I have been lying to you about the Academy. I fight for the Rebellion." Boy is forcing these words.

"You what?" Tall one doesn't like it. Adora looks confused.

"I thought what you would be disappointed if I tell you. And George would be mad, you know how he feels about war." Admission is hard for him.

At this moment blondie tried to move away from the door, but tripped over carpet and fell with loud thud. Feline failed to catch her.

"Who's there?" Boy got his weapon combat ready in a second and aimed it to the door. Hm, Catra would never take him as trigger-happy type. Guy is coming to their direction.

"Bow, it just me!" Adora shouted.

"Adora? What are you doing in here?" Boy lowered his namesake.

"You went into the Woods in the middle of the night." Now standing blondie gave Catra sideway look. "I… I assumed you had a problem."

"You know this girl?" Tall version of Bow come to group too.

“Lance this is Adora. She is fighting the Horde with me. Adora this is Lance. He is my dad.” Boy introduced them to each other.

“Hi.” Adora shudder uncomfortably. She broke into his house after all.

“Hello.” Lance is more friendly.

“Now, if we are done with formalities, Bow, please tell me what is this all about.” Dad guy said in less pleasant tone.

This is just rich. Boy, apparently, more self-aware than Catra thought. He not only someone aside princess’ servant. Bow have a whole life without Rebellion. Boy is so good at playing the role of nice guy that he managed to fool Catra. She laughed.

“I was going to, but Adora showed up.” Boy reached for his device.

“My trackerpad started to receive strange messages after incident with the princess a week ago.” Feline’s laugh abruptly ends. A week?! Why Adora didn’t say anything? Blondie glared at her. She responds in kind.

“It asked questions about Glimmer, about who I am without her. Sender knew very specific information. I fear what next transmission will be about my family. I wanted to warn you before you get hurt because of my participation in the Rebellion.”

“Bow.” Adora redirected her focus to boy. Not now then.

“I planned to tell you tomorrow. I mean it is today now. Second bunch of messages arrived when you were with Glimmer. I didn’t know what to do.”

Rest of conversation is not interesting to Catra. She went cruising around the room. Big crystal in one of glass containers, attracted her attention. It resembling Black Garnet in miniature, material looks the same, but color is pink.

Adora liked her magic tricks, huh? She'll show her magic. She stick arm inside crystal.

"Detaitini locotorp draugefas. Deined ssecca"

Clang of metal came from the sphere upstairs. It's reconfigured itself in worm-like creature with sharp blades on tentacles that poking out of its body. Eyes turned to people below.

"For the honor of Greyskull!" Adora don't hesitate. Bow shot goo arrow at the monster. Have they met these before? Arrow glued monster to railing, which is creaking at its effort to move. She-Ra jumped at creature and begun to smashing it with the sword.

Catra couldn't do anything to shard, but worm looks more mechanical than stony. Worth a try. She appeared at the side of automaton. Ghost wants it to stop. For starters. She pulled her arms in worm's internals. It is pushing her away. But not strong enough. Feline reached the core. Monster paused.

"Adora, I got this, stop bushing it." She-Ra glanced at her. And decapitated robot while it's vulnerable. Head fell to lower level.

"I said I got this!" Well, if blondie angry for her dumb friend, then feline is angry now too.

"I done here. Bow, sorry, I need to go." They are not delaying this talk.

"What are you doing?!" Adora throw at her once they are outside.

"I took control on the worm, that you were doing?!" Did they last at least a day without a fight?

"You awakened the guardian first." Her friend less agitated after initial phrase. But not for much.

“It was an accident.” So, Adora knows about creatures like this.

“Okay. Then what do you have to say about messages to Bow?” What Catra wanted to save the guy from same trap of dependency she fell into herself. Bad answer. And it was for nothing.

“First time I told him what princess will not die. Second time I told him what you have dealt with her attacker. I can’t imagine why boy thought what I was threatening to harm his ‘dad’ or his family.”

“Catra, you are not telling me something.”

“Like *you* tell me everything! Why you didn’t say that you have been underground for a week?” Feline is more disturbed by Adora’s actions than her lag.

Blondie is dumbfounded. “You didn’t know?”

“You through I waited you for this long and just accepted it after?”

Her friend doesn’t say anything. So, answer is yes.

“Sorry.” This doesn’t make it better.

“Sorry too. For awaking stupid guard .” But for Adora this is matter. And Catra will never let go of her.

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Duo is nearly home. Catra is compensating for their quarrel. She is maintaining touch contact to Adora. A hand in hers. Head on shoulder, carefully placed to keep it from staining.

Palace’ facade is bathing in runestone’ light. It cast no shadows. Magic illumination only emphasize shapes and ornaments. But

rooms insides are gradually shifting to darker color. Safe for a small group of windows. Adora looked in its direction.

“It’s war planning room. Must be Angella. She, probably, never sleeps." Adora is think of something.

"I should have reported to her about Horde base.” Now it’s got into blondie’s head. No use, they are going.

“Then pay her a visit.”

Pair walked in the hall. Catra is here for the first time. Table in the center of the room flooded with papers at Queen’ side. Most chair are in perfect order. No one using them, as it seems. Murals on the walls and ceiling display ancient battles and equally ancient warlords. With some recent exceptions.

“Your Majesty.” Adora slightly bowed. Feline do not.

“Hello, Adora.” Angella acknowledge her presence, but remain concentrated on documents. Catra is examining images on the walls. Perhaps, she can find some familiar from tactic classes.

“I have a report to you about First One’s temple in the Whispering Woods. It is training ground for She-Ra. I need to go in there from time to time. This is the only way for me to unlock more of her powers.” Despite being faulty piece of tech Light Hope could be Catra’s best shot to find solution for her situation. Feline less eager to seek help among princesses and mages, but she doesn’t reject this possibility completely.

“Did you learn anything?” Ghost noticed vaguely familiar scene on the mural. Horde soldiers with armored transporters are entering burning city. The most stand-out detail is what they all are having Brightmoon insignias on armor. This exact event was one of greatest Hordak’ triumph, which gave him shipyards and control on good chunk of the ocean. She can’t remember name of the city. It doesn’t exist anymore anyway.

“Sorry. I still can’t heal. Training is a slow process. But I brought good news too. We don’t have to worry about Horde outpost in ruins of Plumeria anymore. They retreated.” Feline appeared next to one of pots with weird plant, what are scattered near walls.

“I suppose your friend helped you.” Catra froze. She let go of plant leaf she played with and turned to the Queen and her friend. Adora looked at feline too. Angella didn’t moved.

“I must mishear you. Who helped me?” She can’t see her, right?

“You took someone with you, aren’t you? Don’t tell me you stormed this place alone.” Angella finally look up to Adora.

“I…” Adora quickly glanced at Catra “I... was alone. But this won’t happen again.”

“I would like to never raise this topic. Look after yourself. You can write down your report later. Anything else?” Queen was posed in Horde briefings as the most powerful figure in the Rebellion. Angella gave feline a creep at her first day in Brighmoon, even when she just seen her from good distance in the hallway.

“N-No, your Majesty.” Adora went to the exit.

“Let’s get out of here.” Catra doesn't want to spend more time in this place.

“Don’t forget to come see Glimmer.” Angella said to them in the backs.

“Yes, your Majesty.” Adora stopped.

"That goes for you, too."

“W-wh…” Catra slowly faced her.

“She is the only reason you are still there. My daughter figured out how much you mean for Adora. And she care for her.” She know. They know everything. Queen sees her.

“But don’t get used to your state. It is only temporary, and whoever done this to you can take it back.” Catra is trembling.

“And if you try to hurt anyone...”

“I’ll put the end to this myself.” Catra feel paralysis. Her legs don't listen to her. She is helpless, in fear, at the mercy of someone with much more power. Just like before.

"You are free to leave."

"Catra!" Her friend is shaking her.

"Catra, snap out of it." Adora grabbed feline by arm and started to dragging her out of the room. Ghost regained control over her body. Pair ran away in the night again.

The Storm

Chapter Notes

[4] In Circles by Ashley Barrett

Queen unleashed Catra's fear again. She is here on borrowed time and she can run out of it very soon. Feline doesn't belong to this world anymore. Whatever sick magic made her to stick around, it won't last for long.

And another witch treated her, that she can make sure Catra won't meet next day. Ghost couldn’t bear staying so close to her. She bolted. Outside the wing, outside the palace, outside the city. Only under trees shadows she became aware of her surroundings. She needs hideaway.

"Catra! Wait!" Adora pursued her.

"Please. Don't run away." Ghost paused. A few seconds after rebel bumped into her back, hugging Catra from behind. Feeling of deja vu enveloped her. But now she is on the other side of the scene. "I don't know what will happen with me, if you vanish."

"Rebel Queen wants me gone." Words slipped before she could stop them.

"This is not the Horde. She is not Shadow Weaver. They won't hurt you." Adora's grip around her tightens.

"Okay." She simply said. Even if her faith in rebel's "good guys" thing is wearing thin, the only person worth enough for her to keep going is with them.

"But I won't go back tonight." Catra putted her arms above blondie's.

"No one makes you to. We can camp in the Woods near the city." Ghost gently tried to unclasp herself. Usually, she would enjoy

every second of blondie' affection, but her grip is too strong. It's reminds Catra suffocating embrace of shadows too much at this moment.

She needs to get out. She needs to get Adora's arms away.

Blackened clawed hands merged with pale hands of her friend. Dissolved without a trace. Catra forcedly threw her... their limbs to the sides. Made a few steps forward. Looked down. Her own arms are back.

"Oh. What was that? You could just tell me to let you go." Actually, yes, she could, or she could have used one of her *others* new abilities to break out of Adora's hold.

"Ugh." She's not going to deal with it right now. It's already too much. Catra put on mask of sarcasm to hide her disturbed state. "And you would do this?"

"Maybe?" Feline can see by her friend's face, what it means no.

"Whatever. Come on, I have better idea than to lay on the ground." Catra walked in direction where pair left the tank.

Hideout ghost decided to occupy while waiting for the morning outside the city doesn’t have much space and not comfortable. But she doesn't need sleep. Unlike her friend. Still, it's better than forest floor.

"Hideout" also is too far stretched. Horde battle machines not exactly designed to be inconspicuous. Their purpose is to destruct and to protect soldiers inside. Currently, second feature is more than welcomed by Catra. Irrational part of her wants physical barrier between her and the Rebellion base, armor plates could take significant damage before give in.

Ghost hover on the top of vehicle, open the hatch with foot and slide inside. Blondie shortly after lowered herself in seat close to her. Pressed into her side. Feline restored the distance. Just in case.

But it is reminded Catra how Adora often tried to sooth young feline after particularly nasty torments back in the Horde or when she was hiding from said torments. Even if Catra lashed out on her attempts.

Feline turn on and dim interface screen after Adora drifted out of conscience to let her rest until dawn. She is monitoring camera's feed, dreading to find winged silhouette in the sky. Angella may reconsider.

Because plans to make Catra come to Brightmoon were dumb. It was naive to think what they would let her in after she mauled heir of the throne. Or at all. Similar plans to play along with demands of superiors back in Fright Zone have failed, the witch got rid of feline the second she couldn’t use Catra to bring back her perfect cadet.

Following Adora's lead makes her go rounds. She is nobody without her. And she is nobody with her. Initial euphoria from finding out what her feelings are mutual ended. Unsurprisingly, it didn't make everything perfect. Feline is walking on the blade edge over the abyss. With no way out, and her days counted.

On the top of already big pile of Catra’s problem is Queen's order to Adora to meet with Glimmer. If her only friend haven't drastically changed, while ghost in frozen wastelands was trying to make peace with her own deceasing, Adora will certainly visit princess at the first possibility. And she will make ghost to accompany her.

No guarantees what it's not some elaborate trap, to get excuse for Angella's revenge. And Shadow Weaver kept her grip around ghost as winged magician' said. Adora can’t help with neither of this.

Catra is out of options. The only lead she had remained on learning how to extend her existence is phantom from the dead forest. But she won't ask Adora to come together. Another phantom could go straight to kill, if she shows up. Going alone in

the middle of the night means another scene, if she notices feline vanishing. Catra can't count on outcome of it and she won't risk it. Adora won’t allow ghost go for it by herself. She doesn’t trust her. Encounter in the boy’s house made it clear.

It isn't news for her. Adora never believed that Catra could do anything as good as praised cadet, or achieve something on her own. Every time feline almost succeed she ribbed failure in her nose. Every time Catra DID succeed was ignored or quickly forgotten. But it was never enough to push young feline away.

Now Catra just know what exactly she carved for so long. Adora's love is sweet, but has bitter aftertaste, it is wish come true, but it demands to give up on everything including herself, it will last forever, but forever means as long as it is convenient.

Lighter shade of green is growing on the screen. Horizon becomes brighter.

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“Catra.” Adora quietly said and shifted in the seat, searching for her. She feels moisture in the corners of her grey eyes.

“Nightmare again?” Feline turned in her direction. Adora nodded. Ghost scrambled to her side, slipped one arm behind blondie’ back and other clasped around chest, snuggling her. Behavior like this was uncharacteristic for Catra before... Before. But is comforting to be able to touch her. Especially after another nightmarish vision.

Though, it would be more calming if she didn't have to look in empty eye-sockets and be so aware why her palms are so rough.

Adora stretched her arm to scratch behind that left of ears. Friends figured out accidentally during one of their childplays how good it felt for feline. She hadn't allowed blondie to do it for a while. Hollow eyes never left hers until Adora stopped scratching due to uneasiness of the stare.

Interface monitor little by little grow brighter. Morning begun. Eventually blondie made a move to end embrace.

“We should go visit Glimmer.” Adora started to putting on her boots and jacket. Limited room isn't helping with the task. She hit some protrusions with her elbows a few times.

“I don’t. Nothing good will happen if I go there.” She understands Catra's hesitation to meet princess. Really. But they must do it.

“Please. It’ll be okay. Angella herself said that Glimmer understand who you are to me. And that they won't do anything to you.” Which was another Rebellion oddity, but it not like Adora is expert in their customs. Maybe it somehow connected to what all other ghosts are princesses.

“Fine.”

On the road to private hospital Adora couldn't help but notice how *still* Catra is. How she could just freeze between steps. Gone are dozens of unconscious little motions human spent years to learn and understand. All feline's actions are too accurate and repetitive. Like big part of personality was ripped out of her.

Hallway to the ward is blocked by a sorcerer. Adora saw some of them in Brightmoon, but not close. Magicians were using their powers to refresh spells and runes, which ensures citizens everyday life in the city. One of such runes reside on the ward’s door.

“Greeting, She-ra. You have permission to enter” Hooded person in robe spoke.

"At least they took me seriously." Catra said nonchalantly.

"Excuse me, but you were told the reason why princess needs guard, or Queen only takes precautions?" Adora wants to know if people started to finding out about Catra's presence. Not being seen as delirious when she talks with her on the streets would be a plus.

"We were notified of latest development regarding *flaws* in city defense." Mage fiddled with his hands. "We would appreciate if you or your companion could provide ideas for possible countermeasures against similar threats."

Ghost took a step forward and waved her hands near mage's face. He didn't react. "Nope, still invisible. Also, you can tell him if Shadow Weaver could do this, they would already drown in angry undeads."

"Catra, stop it. You are being rude." Her friend's antics made her to crack a smile for a second. "We think it's unlikely to repeat." Goes to the mage.

"Well, then. I won't hold you up any longer. I must send a message to my colleagues." Sorcerer walked to the far end of the corridor, opened window and casted a spell. Bird, woven from the strings of light, flew in the air. Adora went into princess' room.

***[4]

"Good morning, Glimmer." Princess usually sleep in, but considering what there is not much else to do for her on bedrest, it isn't surprising what she is awake.

"Good morning, Adora." Look on Glimmer' face became sour. "Mom posted a babysitter at my door last night. Can you believe it?"

"Yeah, sorry for that." Maybe, if Adora introduced Catra earlier, like when she first met her at the park, they could have avoided it.

"Why are you are apologizing? It's not like you had any part in it." Glimmer often was amused by blondie's habit to apologize for everything.

"We, kind of, had? Angella did say what Catra can stay, but she worries about you." Or she worries what Adora can't handle ghost herself.

"You talked with my mom about bringing defector before me?" Glimmer pouted. "And what is so important about Catra what you think she would want to join us?"

"But... but... I thought you know what she means for me... And that's why you..." Blondie rambled.

“Let's get this over with.” Feline came into view on the soft chair in far corner, legs bending over the armrest, back laying on the other one. She isn't looking at the royal.

“You brought her here?” Glimmer tried to raise her voice, but it broke. Light starts to gathering in her hands.

“Angella told her to come.” “I am not thrilled about it too, Glitter.” They said simultaneously. Adora winced. This is serious. But Catra, being herself, is insulting the person, who can help her to stay in Brightmoon.

"Adora, is she the "complicate details" you kept quiet about?" Purple magic orbs are filling room with buzzing. Feline didn't even bother to turn head in their direction.

"I wanted to tell you, but hadn't known how." Adora needs her. And she was helpful already. Glimmer has to understand. "I swear Catra is on our side now. We dealt with Horde camp in Plumeria together. She'll help the Rebellion if you give her a chance."

"It wasn't an illusion in my palace, didn't it?" Glimmer said after pause.

"No." She can't think of excuse for it nor hide it. Adora feels the ground slipping away from underneath her feet.

“What is the deal with her? She burst into my party, almost slashed me in a half and now sitting there like nothing happened.” Glimmer seethed.

“So, it is ME who broke into your life and completely destroyed it?!” Catra jumped up. Princess' hands jerked at her movement.

“You took Adora away! And Shadow Weaver didn’t hesitate to put her death threats into actions, when I returned without her!” Princess’ quiet protests drown in ghost’ shouts.

“Catra, stop! Glimmer couldn’t have known what Shadow Weaver would do to you.” This is bad, Adora can’t let her friend antagonize princess. More than she already is.

“Now she knows.” Feline approached the bed. She bared her teeth in scowl. Glimmer looks like she is about blast feline with all magic she had. “So, tell me how it feels to be a murderer, because I didn’t have guts to learn it myself.”

Soldier got in between Glimmer and Catra. Facing feline, but efficiently blocking her from princess' magic. “Catra, it’s not her fault! Listen, I am sorry I left you. I didn't want things to turn out this way. But I had no choice. Why you can't understand?”

"You always had a choice to run away with me before the damn sword. Neck, you could have taken me with you *when you went for it*. I would follow. I wanted to. You saw how she treated me. And it wasn't good enough reason for you. But you meet a pair of idiots from the outside and only then you realize that Horde are bad guys." Feline' form flickered, revealing the full extent of her wounds.

"Now I know that exactly I worth for you. And if what is your love so be it."

Silence is deafening.

"Love?" Glimmer said with husky voice. Quick look behind soldier's back showed princess' wild eyes. Spheres of light in her fists fizzled out.

"Catra, you are everything for me. Why are you thinking of yourself as anything less than that?" Adora pleadingly raised her arms.

"Because the only time when you could have made a difference. When you could have saved me. You didn't. You walked away." Feline moved towards soldier, her face right next to Adora's. Ghost is spitting out words along with plumes of smoke. "And! Now you are saying! What it was your decision alone! What princesses!! With their magic bullshit!! Have nothing to do with this!!!"

She grabbed Adora by arms. "I tried to push all these thoughts down! I tried to pretend that we could go on like this! I tried to forgive you for leaving me to die! But I can't! Not when you are constantly reminding me that you could keep watch me suffer as long as it was for that you thought is greater good! When you went away despite what you loved me! When I know that you'll throw me aside if I'll be too inconvenient for rebels!" Catra suddenly retracted. Jacket is ashen where she touched it.

"So, stop lying. You never were good at this. I don't mean world to you. But you walked away to save one I wasn't a part of." She doesn't even sound angry anymore, her tone is flat and without feline's tale-tell signs it hard to read that is on her mind.

"You are right. I can't give up on everything to be with you." Realization hurts. That she really would choose to harm Catra if it helped everybody else. And what she did it already. Adora just hope it never will come to this again. "But I don't have to. We can be together. I can figure out how to help you. No one will make us go apart."

"It's not up to you to decide." Ghost looked past soldier. "Just call for the Queen, Glitter, if you can't stand me. She'll gladly dispose of me for you. Because I won't go anywhere, I have nothing and no one aside Adora. And she decided to play a rebel for a while."

Adora turned to third occupant of the room. "Glimmer, please, tell her that she is safe here. Rebellion is better than that." It was one of initial reasons she went with them.

"Don't tell me what to do." Angered princess summoned purple magic back.

"You... You can't." She isn't serious, she can't be.

"No, it's you can't bring your buddy from the Horde, who tried to kill me, put me before the fact what, apparently, she is good now and should stay at my home." Glimmer aimed at Catra with seeming struggle. "Step aside, Adora."

"I won't." She stubbornly kept standing between the rebel and the ghost.

"Then talk to me! Stop shutting me out and demand something from me next!" That managed to get Glimmer to scream. Red slowly bloomed on white of her gown.

"Glimmer, you are bleeding."

"Don't change the subject. Give me a single reason why I shouldn't blast her." Her voice subsided, but not much. **[4]End]**

"I can't turn into She-ra without her." Adora blurted out.

In the temple only when she thought of Catra she managed to access She-ra' power. All advices from Light Hope didn't helped. When Adora heard alarm at the base, she was convinced what soldiers somehow found Catra. She rushed in for her as fast as she could. Adora never spoke her chanting in such short time.

"You figured out how to become She-ra when she wasn't there." Glimmer said irritated.

Blondie sighed. "I haven't felt She-ra at all since Salinias. I haven't wanted to fight. I wished I had drowned sword in the ocean. And when I tried to heal you a week ago, it didn't react at all, Angella had seen it." Only Catra and Queen knew about her troubles with She-ra' magic after she fought illusion. No one should have known, even with feline it slipped up because of happiness from reunion. If other princesses learn what Adora could lose control on She-ra, they would never join the Alliance. Or worse, Mermista could withdraw.

"But when I met Catra in the Woods, while searching for temple, She-ra... awoke, I think. It is hard to describe. Now, please let me call the medic." Red lines on the fabric of Glimmer' gown reached the bed-sheet.

"Argh, okay, Adora." Princess putted her hands down, dropping magic. "But you will tell me *everything* from the beginning. And I call Bow, you owe him explanation too."

She reached for nightstand, and batted Adora's arm when she went to help. Soldier left the ward to fetch doctor.

***

"No immediate execution? Great. I already see how rebels are soooo much better than the Horde." Catra reappeared in laying position at the chair. Her attempt to annoy princess might seems unwise, but feline knows how people in power think. Royals already decided what they could use her. Adora handled them over information that she has interest in Catra. Princesses will take advantage of this weakness when blondie get bored with them. If ghost last for that long.

"Don't test me." Princess grumble through clenched teeth while poking into the rebel's version of tablet, that she retrieved from the drawer of nightstand. "If I won't like that Adora tell me you're done."

"Yeah yeah, been there done that. You need to become less sparkly before try to intimidate me, glitter pouf." At that Glimmer threw a bunch of sparkles into feline' head. Ghost form only lose clarity for a moment. She hoarsely cackled. Princess' magic was pathetic. Catra began to doubt if it is able to hurt her at all.

"Hello, Glimmer." Archer picked up the call.

"Bow. Are you close, can you come over?" Princess' face lightened a little bit.

"I am at my parents place, I'll be in a few hours."

"Where they even live? Although, it's not important. Adora has a lot to tell us, you'll have to listen through tracker pad. It's urgent."

Said girl soon returned with the medic in tow. Doctor proceeded to reapplying sealing spells on princess' side. Adora greeted Bow and started to retelling to rebels her interactions with Catra, real one and her shadow, since she got first vision from the sword in Whispering Woods. Leaving out most private part, including the nightmare. For which feline was thankful, she wasn't sure if blondie took "everything" literally or not. Medic left girls alone after reminding princess to not overexert, and Adora to not stress her. Doctor on the way out disapprovingly frowned on filthy chair.

Glimmer looked like she was about to interrupt the story a few times, but she didn't. Bow politely listened to the end. At last blondie covered all important missing parts completing with last night events. She is nervously waiting for her rebel friends answer.

Finally Glimmer broke silence. "You know, I couldn't get my head around why you have beaten yourself up so hard over one Horde soldier after mission to recruit Mermista. I knew you both had a history together, but not to this extent. I even talked with my mom about how you were sulking, if she had any advice to help you get better sooner. She told me what you only need time and all support from friends we could give, that we shouldn't leave you alone no matter what. You were supposed to recover at your own pace. I think, she realized what you lost love of your life that day." She slowly made a breath.

"I wish you trusted us enough to open up earlier. I see why you didn't, but I still regret it. I'm glad you are able to meet her again, though. What Catra did is bad, but if she genuinely wants to help us, then we'll figure something out. Besides, Angella agreed to give her a chance. We aren't cruel monsters to make you choose between your love and us." Bow commented through the device.

"Just why does she have to be such a bitch?" Glimmer complained.

"Dying does that a to person. But you are a talent. You are good at this without it." Princess pulled a long face at feline's retaliation.

"Okay, guys, let's not start fighting." Adora decided to play peacemaker.

"Adora, can you take Catra somewhere else? I have had enough of her for today. Bow, I know you would like to talk with Adora more, but her girlfriend is insufferable, believe me."

"Hey, watch it, Sparkles. I am not just some friend girl of her. We are the best friends." Dumb rebels can't even tell two these things apart.

"Go already."

"Okay, Glimmer. Goodbye." Blondie pulled Catra toward the exit.

In corridor sorcerer intercepted Adora again.

"She-ra. Queen would appreciated if you subsequently refrain from putting princess' health in jeopardy."

"Sorry. I haven't thought her reaction would be this bad. It won't happen again." Blondie said guilty.

"Spell around her ward is strong, but my ability to protect princess is limited when danger crossed it." Wait, is he hinting at...

"What is your specialization in magic?" Adora got feline's suspicions too.

"I am architect. I maintain spires of the city." The Rebellion posted a technician to guard princess. If they are in so desperate situation, blondie won't be sticking with them for long. She never enjoyed defeat.

"And you are acting as a guard."

"As per Head Sorcerer' order all battle capable mages should not leave Mystacor ground. She has little love toward Rebellion Queen and her cause. My assignment as a protector was allowed only because princess Glimmer is her niece." Whatever that means. But a divide between magicians could be useful. They could be more eager to share information they have on cursed magic Shadow Weaver used on Catra, than Rebellion.

"Adora, ask him there Mystacor is. Mages could know thing or two about ghosts."

"Can we visit Mystacor?"

"The city is hidden, without a guide it won't be possible for you. You can request help from one of my colleagues, of course. But Queen must give her permission." Another dead end. The poisoned forest still her only option.

"Thanks. We'll go then."

"Have a nice day."

Pair ended up in the park during their wandering across Brightmoon. They see a few citizens doing their own promenade, but paths are mostly deserted. Clouds have gathered in the sky while Adora was wasting her time on princess. It will be raining soon. Blondie needs to hide. However, water in clouds outside Fright Zone may occur to be not acidic.

"What are we doing here? Don't you have important rebellion duties?" Catra lost her patience. Adora was clearly searching for a right moment to give her the talk.

"You are important. I want you to know what if Glimmer had refused to let you stay in Brightmoon, I would go away with you. I don't need to live in a palace to fight the Horde. If I can't protect you with Rebellion, I'll find a place where I can." Catra don't

believe a single word. It easy to say when blondie is sure she'll never have to act on them.

"The only people you tried to protect me from are your new so-called friends. No one else can hurt me any further." Aside Shadow Weaver. It will be quite a view when Adora confront her. A very sad and short view for ghost.

"No one will hurt you. I promise." Adora, of course, believes the lie she is saying.

Spark

Chapter Notes

Spark as in spark of fire.
[5] Slow Life - Of Monsters and Men

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora very well knows how her friend acts when she is mad at someone. But she rarely found herself at the receiving end of that Catra, and never for long. **[5]**

Feline always was very emotional. And what for three whole days since Queen and princess accepted her in the Rebellion, Catra was almost constantly upset with Adora made it a problem. *Almost* means ghost's strange mood swings when she could burst in sincere laugh on Adora's attempts to cheer her up and fell back to being irritated and sorrowful next minute. This and continuing bad dreams are wearing down on Adora.

She grew desperate. She needs to bring at least one of these things back to normal. Sleep aids only took away her ability to wake up from nightmares before the end. Without them, if Adora was lucky, she jolts up after first zap. But good night sleep isn't a thing anymore.

Adora is running low on ideas how to make her "girlfriend", as Glimmer calls Catra, be more like she was after the temple, or more specifically how she was in her room that day, whole and undamaged. Her last best plan is to make ghost try food, which she never got a chance to taste. She would call it genius by several reasons.

Crash Glass shattered. Downside of the plan is Catra's disdain toward fragile unsecured rebels' items.

"Catra, can you don't break their tableware?" Adora whispered. She hears her anyway, despite what public dinner hall in the

palace is full of guards, servants, low ranked clerks and scribes.

"Rebels hate me anyway, one or dozen broken mugs won't make a difference. Besides, if they want their *tablewares* intact, they shouldn't leave it at the edge of the table." Feline started to move another hapless clerk's glass toward it's doom.

"They aren't, people learned not to when me and you are around. Just wait, I'll take the plate and we come to my room." *Crash* "Catra, please, I have something for you, but I need that plate first."

"And what is it?" Feline approached her.

"It's a surprise."

Worker on food distribution duty made a sign what Adora's order is ready. Phew. She took it and pair went to her apartment. Blondie lay plate of various sweets on her working table.

"Close your eyes."

"If it some kind of joke, you'll regret it." She cautioned Adora. Feline' expression didn't change.

"Did you..." Adora thinks she'll never be able to get used to how ghost looks. For some reason eyes were the most disturbing detail for her.

"Can't you see?!"

"You just... Never mind." This time blondie is sure she'll make feline happy. Adora took a tiny bite from a piece of cake from the dish. She hesitated. But it is Catra under all of this. Very angry Catra with who she is trying to make up. Adora went for a kiss first time since their night after returning in the city.

Lips of that Catra are rough, dry and still the same only ones she wants. Blondie pushed tongue with bits of sweets into feline' mouth and tried to find her. Adora more or less knows that it

necessary to touch food by tongue to feel the taste. Pair lingered in the moment.

Adora was first to depart. She needed air.

"Did it work? You tasted the cake? Did you like it?" Blondie asks between breaths.

"Hmm." Catra's tone turned sly. "I'm not sure. We'll have to do it again."

"Give me a second." Adora took a thermos with "tchea" out of lower drawer. Glimmer taught her to drink it to wash taste from previous dish. It can as well wash away ashy taste from the kiss and cake's leftovers. Blondie wanted nothing to lessen the impression from Brightmoon's food for Catra.

As Adora putted thermos cap down feline pulled her into kiss herself. Pointy teeth caught her lip. Catra left her absolutely breathless again both literally and figuratively.

"Yes. I think I like this." Feline is smiling.

"But I didn't have sweets?" Blondie' plan was to bribe Catra with it. Adora kissing her was only a bonus, she was a little concerned about possibility what feline could chew off her lips if she suggests kisses alone.

"I wasn't talking about the cake, idiot" Last word was said like she was glad what Adora is an idiot.

"The idiot you like to kiss. And who it makes you?" Two can play this game.

"A girl, for who even death wasn't enough to not coming back to you." Catra's smile disappeared. First sign of upcoming mood drops. But she was so close this time. Why it failed too? "Adora, I always had and I always will love you. I'll be with you no matter what. But what is your plan now? If it's not about ruling the

world." Adora caught barely audible "together" when Catra begun trail off in the end. Asking about this will make everything worse.

"I am Etheria's chosen champion. I have destiny to save the planet and restore the balance." Adora needs these words, the defined goal since sense of righteousness was too little for her to fight for after she had to "kill" Catra with her own hands because of it. Light Hope gave form Adora's vague feelings.

"Still going big, huh?" Edge in feline's voice become palpable. "Good for you, I guess." Something broke inside Adora at how she said it.

"Catra, please, I can't take this anymore. You are safe behind me at my side, I love you too. And I don't know what else I can do to prove what I won't let go of you." Abruptly aborted hiss sounded from feline. "If you are bothered because we didn't make any progress on ghost thing, I will fix it. I can ask the Queen..."

"Keep her out of it." Catra growled. She wasn't *that* angry for a past few days. It seems, rebels are a really sore spot, which is unsettling ghost even further. Though, not involving rebels isn't an option, last time Catra putted Glimmer in med house after asking this from Adora.

"I even tell you what," Adora got very very ugly feeling about that Catra is going to say, and she is so so tired. Girl got crazy idea how to stop her. "keep yourse..."

Narrowing small gap between them, blondie putted her mouth over Catra's. Feline melted under touch. Adora relieved.

"Whoa, princess made you as soft as animal-shaped pillows in her room." Catra was in Glimmer's room? Blondie was going to press on topic, but feline put a pressure on Adora's mouth with her own. It is more interesting than a reason why Catra had visited royal' bedroom and definitely better than what she had tried to say.

Moreover, it makes her friend happier. And Adora needs Catra as she remembers her. **[5]End]**

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Routine patrol missions in Whispering Woods started with fanfares. At war meeting Queen informed Adora what scouts discovered active Horde operation at the borders of Whispering Woods. But she refuses to send regular warriors this close to Fright Zone without preparations. She-ra' task is to determine numbers of enemy forces and fend off groups which delved in the forest territory. Citizens of Brightmoon organized solemn farewell with flowers and ribbons on the road outside the city for their hero.

To quote Glimmer "This is the largest move against the Horde mom made in the decade." She wasn't happy about missing it. Though that Catra leaves Brightmoon were a welcomed news for her.

Bow was still torn between settling things with his family and keeping company to Glimmer while she recovers, thus he is skipping as well. The most he could help is to give to Adora one of his communication devices.

One trip to the forest turned into two, then into long term assignment with some rest time. Angella hadn't gone further than accepting blondie's reports. No plans on attacking the camp, no supporting units on patrols, only suspense.

Soldiers, who managed to escape from people eating woods after Adora had beaten them up at the first patrol, begun to return on duty.

Catra wonders what they're doing out there. Queen clearly doesn't want to win the war, otherwise Rebellion would launch an attack already. She has better ways to make Catra stay away from the princess without weakening control on Adora. The best guess feline has is that Angella dragging out time, keeping restless hero

occupied with minor mission to make her more docile. The question is what Queen is waiting for? She is temporarily down one of her pawns, but that couldn't be the reason for delaying.

Idleness when something big is going on was never good for Catra. Adora is driving away darkest of ghost's thoughts with more pleasant activities, but they can't do this whole time. Feline is bored. There is no fun in hunting if animals don't react. Helping She-ra with rare small reconnaissance squads too much of a chore. They are barely above annoyance for giant warrior. Though, the princess eagerly beats the living crap out of her previous allies.

The most trouble soldiers are making is disturbing Catra and Adora late in the evening when blondie turn back into herself and pair can just be with each other. Skirmishes are mood killers, or, if to speak more specifically, Adora' magic transformations are. She-ra' features, which obscure the ones of her best friend, her silly cloth, which blondie would never choose to wear, and don't forget ridiculous tiara. This all is getting on Catra's nerves. It pushes feline' mind to work on solution.

First, the Horde is using tech. Second, Catra can interact with it easily and not necessarily by direct touch, her new *ghost* abilities are valuable. Third, no fighting is faster than any kind of fight. Fourth, She-ra is known among soldier ranks as force capable to annihilate everything what Horde threw on her so far.

So, it's in everybody interest, perhaps, rebels excluding, to avoid encounters. And ghost has means to make patrols do not come to her and Adora's camp accidentally. If it were accidents and not Whispering Woods itself led soldiers to their location.

"Hey, Adora, I'll go check if there is some squad about to stumble upon us again." Catra said, as blondie preparing campsite for the night.

"Finally, decided it's not so bad to help me to do my job? I knew you'll come around." Adora smirked. Girls are on their usual

bickering conditions now.

"No, it's still awfully boring. I just thought if someone sees how dumb you look while kissing air, you will not survive this. And then we'll both stuck as ghosts."

"You are already stuck with me." Blondie cheered.

"In your dreams." In which they are currently live. Exist. Whatever.

Catra went away from the clearing. Forest isn't empty, there is always a noise. Rustle of the grass as inexperienced nocturnal predators crawl in the dark, crackling of branches caused by wind, insectlike elementals' heavy movements. During long walks with Adora feline learned what her senses in current state not a constant, she has control on how much she hears, sees and smells, but it requires all of her attention. Experiments with sight were the weirdest. Catra doesn't try it now. Horde soldiers in full equipment aren't stealthy. Their steps are loud.

She found them. Squad of five. Trail of broken foliage gives out people's foreignness to the woods. Despite resistance, trees pushing soldiers to choose way, which will bring them to Adora's camp. Pair walked this path earlier today and trees aren't in the same positions. Catra groans. Stupid landscape indeed prevents her from having at least something resembling quality time.

Carnivorous forest can suck it up. Feline will ruin it plans. She reaches to grunts' radios in helmets.

"If I was you, I would turn back right now." Soldier in rearguard actually jumps. For a good reason though. Back in Fright Zone Catra heard stories about how Whispering Woods lures platoons into monsters’ den. She is doing quite the opposite, fortunately for scouts.

"Don't try to scare us." Second person in formation answers her. "Your tricks won't help you when we find you."

"Your squad lost contact with others groups hours ago, you are deep in the woods after down. You are scared as is." Catra knew they wouldn't follow a good advice, when they hear one. She continues to persuade soldiers to not mess up one good thing Catra can have.

"And you are heading toward She-ra." This made squad leader to shut up.

"How can we be sure you're not lying?" Yep, she got them on a hook.

"Refuse to trust me? Then go check it out. I think you'll be fine without your heads since you don't use them anyway." She-ra wasn't exactly brutal. Still. Feline can't tell if it was the woods that finished off all rebels' defeated enemies. She wasn't looking at aftermaths of fights too closely. It's not like she can make Adora reconsider her life choices.

People on receiving end of her friend' wraith is another matter.

Radio of soldier in rearguard activated. "Commander, with respect, guys designated to Plumeria' said someone had alerted them that She-ra is coming in a minutes before rebels attacked." That is funny way to describe Catra's little show, but it works in her favor.

"Speaking without permission?"

"Sorry. We won't need permissions if we are dead."

"Excellent point. Squad, listen up. We encountered She-ra and managed to retreat before suffer significant casualties. Our heroic, but insubordinate, squadmate provided cover for withdrawal, and was severely wounded in the fight. Also, we met local resident, who was ready to support brave liberators in their just cause. At least this you should say if someone asks what are we doing at the base." Designated "wounded" grumbles in the helmet awaiting some zaps from stun-baton before leaving the Woods. Soldiers reorganized and went the way they came from.

Success. Tonight will be not perfect, but as close to that as it can gets. Catra was working on hiding her real appearance too. Adora will like it.

Ghost's help to Horde scouts became regular thing. Short interactions with people who aren't Adora, were also entertaining. Catra loves her, but in Fright Zone Kyle, Rogellio and Lonnie were keeping her company as well. She had other members of their team. Or maybe she deceived herself into believing it. She was alone in the end.

Now useless to dwell on it. Catra and Adora are together non-stop, even if part of that time blondie spends lying unconscious while feline doesn't have such luxury.

It could have been useful to let Adora rest. Could have. Catra do that she can, yet blondie barely sleeps. She maintains She-ra' form all day just to chase tiredness away, which is unpleasant in its own way.

So, Catra is in her hypervigilant mode during nighttime to prevent anyone from awaking her best friend earlier, when she detects possible visitors. The forest is persistent on throwing outsiders to Adora' current location. Luckily, the Woods native inhabitants aren't come close to her camp, so feline can get away for a short while.

Ghost left her spot on the top of sleeping blondie she occupied to lull her and reappeared next to intruders. The most stands out detail is their cadet uniform. No body armors. Only one of them has stun-baton. The other looking into a map on tablet. Both cadets around Catra's age. Perhaps, year or two younger.

Doing dumb dares was a part of routine in barracks. But this pair must have outstupid previous most dangerous challenge to jump over ignited incinerator pit. Feline can't think of another reason for them to be here.

"We lost, didn't we?" Boy nervously pointing weapon to nearest bushes.

"We did not, map is recording our path." Girl with the device chuckled. "If a bunch of four-legged rebels are already too much for you... Wait there is some interference..." She lightly knocks on tablet. "Hm, it's gone. There was I?"

"You were saying that going for a trip in Whispering Woods is a bad idea and what you definitely should go home." Catra's voice emitted from the device. Girl startled and dropped it. Stun-baton discharged. Shot made a small hole in trunk of a tree. Teens stepped closer to each other.

Feline tried to use cracked tablet again, but it didn't react. Damn be the girl' clumsiness. Catra has not a lot of options before dragging them away by force.

Last time ghost was talking with non-princess directly she was very determined to save the grunt from icy grave. It created the connection. It gave her power to change course of events. Searching parties she met had chances to survive in the Woods without her additional intrusion, but this pair is doomed. She put hands on cadet's shoulders. They can't feel a thing. Not yet.

"You really need to go."

Links to cadets much weaker than to tech and they are putting a strain on her. It cannot be compared with the easiness of bind to Adora at all. Ghost not certain it worked. Cadets exchanged glances, girl reached down for broken device, boy kept pointing weapon at the trees.

"I know you heard me, stop acting like you didn't."

"Tablet is busted. Guess, we indeed lost now, congrats, you are right. Happy?" Girl ignored her. She is busy with the device.

"What this even was?" Armed cadet kept his aim at Catra for a little longer than others targets. A-ha. She concentrated on the

weapon, grabbed it by the nozzle and pulled out of his hands. Shot flew through her harmlessly when cadet reflexively pushed the trigger.

"You saw me." Guy recoiled and took battle stance. Catra snapped fingers of her free palm next to cadet face gaining no response in return. She hears sound perfectly, but he acts like a deaf person.

One more try and she is done. If they won't cooperate, ghost knocks them out with stun-baton and drags them.

She changed grip around baton to hold it by the handle. With its tip she writes on the ground. "Follow. I will get you out." It took some time. Catra light up surrounding with electricity from low powered weapon, waiting for cadets to read her message.

"These princesses' magic is weird." Hey! She isn't some kind of princess! Princesses are shooting soldiers with lasers and lightnings and slashing them with magic swords! Catra doesn't do any of this! "It broke our map and now definitely luring us into a trap."

"Well. We have to choose. We follow your floating in the air baton, get killed by rebels and then eaten by monsters. Or we wander around without any clue how to return back home and get killed by monsters while being eaten by them."

"Don't joke like this."

"Stop complaining, we screwed either way."

As teens got distracted with the argument, a six-legged predator with opaque hide crept up on them, attracted by noise. Catra quickly shot a few charges at it. Animal yowled and ran away. Feline has to admit, with functional baton it much easier to hit something.

After minor confusion cadet realized what happened.

"That is our answer. It wants us alive for some reason." Girl took a few steps in Catra's direction.

"But for how long?" Boy grudgingly follows suit.

Mercifully, trio's way to barren wasteland, which two of them still consider home, wasn't more roundabout than usually in the Woods. Weak sight and lesser ability to climb is that making pathfinding harder and whole trip deadlier for representatives of the species more common on Etheria than Catra's. And trees' tendency to man-eating.

"Thanks." Cadets said when they reached open space. "Maybe some of rebels aren't bad."

"I am not a rebel." One line by one ghost wrote letters. The wrong idea would bite them in the back one day, if she doesn't set things clear.

Feline let go of weapon and reappeared at her friend side. Teens aren't near them, in relative safety and no longer her concern.

***

Low buzzing. Flash of light. Strike. Searing pain.

And she in the embrace of her love once again. Catra always hold her tight in the morning these days. That feline looks as if nightmare she went through wasn't real, calming Adora even better. Bicolored eyes ground her.

Catra just appeared at the camp like this during one of night breaks, without explanation. They don't discuss this anymore. Adora isn't happy to be reminded about ghost real state when she has no way to rectify it. Her friend doesn't raise the subject first.

Pair can't disregard it forever, though. And today Adora should return to Krystal Castle. Another chance to gain information from

Light Hope. She sent a message to Glimmer and Bow already. Catra knows too. She is quiet on the route to temple.

Adora hugged her before descending underground. Feline said that going with her may be not the brightest idea, as hologram was able to perceive ghost and she still was dissuading Adora in Catra's existence. And blondie thinks the same. Light Hope very explicitly let her know that temple is only for She-ra. And her steed, which she doesn't have.

"Greetings, She-ra" Transparent figure welcomed her in the main hall. "We must proceed to your training. I will start simulation when you are ready."

"Wait, Light Hope" Adora quickly interrupted. "Last time you said what ghosts aren't exist, but then Catra said that you knew that she had attempted to open entrance. I mean, I want to ask if you can tell me why Catra become like this and how can I help her?"

-

Adora's visit to her secret base is a blessing in certain way. With blondie preoccupied with great destiny or whatever nonsense everyone pours into her ears, feline can do something worthwhile and check on the clue at wilted forest.

The phantom, which Catra and Adora met prior ravaging Horde base, hadn't moved. She is sitting in the same position under inactive runestone. Though, number of broken machineries around slightly increased.

"Hey, you!" Catra shouted. "Tell me you have any idea about what freaky magic stuff happened with me."

The woman raised from the ground. Her hairs are dirty, but have originally some light color. At closer distance Catra recognized her rags as partial set of impractical rebellion armor. Tears in the cloth are showing enough of skin to notice painfully familiar characteristics black marks from lighting strike.

Phantom run toward feline. Right fist above the head telegraphs her prepared swing. Moves display her uncustomary to hand-to-hand combat.

When woman threw a punch, Catra sidestepped and tripped her legs. Phantom remains hang in the air. She really should have known better.

"Leave this place!" Former rebel turned to her and attempted another awkward attack.

"I will leave after you answer my questions." This time Catra deflected fist and punched phantom in the face. It fractured at the impact, fissures covered the cheek. And, most importantly, feline felt the contact. Phantom resisted her instead of trying to slip away. It's good what Catra spared claws for her, otherwise things could have taken drastic turn.

"Ouch. It hurts." Woman whined. She lifted her hand to the cheek. "What would someone from Evil Horde want to learn from me? You only interested in war, and I couldn't fight even when you were destroying my home."

"I am not Horde. Not anymore. But you were a rebel. You guys should know magic garbage. It's your whole thing." Feline can only hope what deceased rebel isn't as clueless as she. It would be such a waste of time. "Tell me about the curse Shadow Weaver used to raise me from the dead as ghost and I'll be on my way."

"There is no magic to make ghosts. They are creatures from fairytales." Woman's countenance is puzzled.

"Then who I am to you? And who you are, so to speak?" Feline can't believe she has this conversation.

"Erm. To me it looks like you are a young girl with strong affinity to magic, given that we can interact with each other." With Catra's luck it sounds about right. That part there she affected by magic worse than average person when a lot of her enemies use magic. It is just yet another confirmation that universe hates her.

"As for me, I am..."

-

"... Pure manifestation of runestone magic." Light Hope continuities. "When balance is disturbed, their intended purpose is to help in reconnection on their side. Personality of these beings bases on memories of most suitable individual to this task. As a rule, most recent previous user of runestone chosen. But exceptions are possible."

"But that doesn't make any sense! Catra never had connection to any runestone and she isn't a princess to be able to create one in the first place." To be honest Light Hope raised more questions than she answered. "She doesn't even..."

-

"...look like a princess to you?!" Dead woman cringed as Catra dropped her illusion. Yes, in comparison to feline in this form she is a beauty.

"There is no other explanation. I can't understand how you wasn't aware of your connection prior our meeting, but if you went through such terrible torture not long after bounding with runestone, it is possible for you to not remember." Catra currently holding, apparently, ex-princess by neck and put her razor-sharp claws next to her face. Rebel will think twice before lying to her.

"Nothing is magical in me except what witch did! Cut the crap and tell me the truth! I am not a monster like you!"

"You are indeed different from me. It seems..."

-

"...Connection to its runestone is corrupted. Runestones were destroyed and conquered during wars between kingdoms over the course of history. But they are able to choose their new users if old ones not available. Loss of a runestone does a great harm to

the planet. Yet forced usage of corrupted connection by person refused by runestone could possibly cause more dire consequences. Black Garnet one of key elements for the balance on Etheria." Holographic demonstration showed how plenty of multicolored glowing point faded on the surface of the planet. Some of them lighted up again, some did not. At last only around dozen points stay illuminated.

"Then why if Catra's mission so important she is with me all the time?" As much Adora is happy to have her friend close, there is fate of the planet at stake.

"Manifestation of magic, which uses Catra's personality from runestone's memory banks, was affected by the corruption. Controlling commands weren't applied properly. Error was examined and defined as uncritical for completion of the task. Deletion was deemed unnecessary." Adora's stomach froze. Her mentor just casualty mentioned what she considered to take Catra away from her. And she wouldn't be aware of it if Light Hope did. Adora would think what Catra run away or that it was a shadow again. "The side effect of corruption..."

-

"...Allow you to be free." Woman smiled sadly. "I am so envious of you. My runestone tethered me to area near it. I can't even try to search for my daughter. She is alive, I know it, but without her I'll never heal Heart-Blossom' host tree. And my purpose cannot be fulfilled."

"Oh, I get it. You want me to find damn princess, bring her to you for some awful ritual and then you tell how to reverse the curse. I scratch your back, you scratch mine? Yeah, well, that's not gonna happen!" Catra's fingertips slightly penetrated the surface of phantom' form. Cracks begun to spread in broken area. Rebel heart-rendingly squealed.

"Answer! Now!" Feline barked.

"You were killed after you created a connection to runestone and essence of your being was absorbed it!" Woman spoke very quickly with high-pitched voice. "It is not the curse and death aren’t a disease to cure! As far as I know no one possess the power to restore a person to life!"

Catra fiercely yelled and let go of the princess. Her words are logical. Why would she stayed ghost-thing if rebels were able to resurrect?

One moment. *She* knows. Shadow Weaver, who murdered this woman, hadn't left Fright Zone for a long time and has no reasons to start now. *She* is dead for a long time. Adora has power of She-ra for a few months. From that feline gathered she supposed to be ancient almighty hero.

"Even your She-ra isn't powerful enough?" If Catra can't do it herself then the only magic wielder who doesn't want her gone, perhaps, could. As much as she hates to bring blondie in it, she hates to stay dead much more.

"She-ra is a fairytale too. If she wasn't, my home wouldn't be in ruins." Princess nervously said.

"Breaking news. She is real, we are travel together, and She-ra just was too slow to save your stupid trees, because your people didn't want to lift a finger to help themselves." If Adora will be too slow to help her too... Well...

The most useful piece of information Catra got from rebel is what magic won't vanish on its own. It's simplified survival to maneuvering around the Queen and hiding from Shadow Weaver. Thought what She-ra could be a solution she considered before. The part when phantom called her a princess Catra dismissed as nonsense. However, what runestone can change owner is interesting to her. Implication makes her want to throw up, which feline was absolutely certain she isn't able anymore and it makes her even sicker, but if it comes to direct confrontation with Horde

Second-in-Command, connection to runestone can give her an upper hand.

"I don't remember any legend about She-ra bringing people back to life. It doesn't mean she can't, though. Strong attachment for so powerful magical being as She-ra..." Dead rebel begun.

-

"...will lead to a catastrophe." Hologram frowned. "Adora you must understand. This magical construct never was Catra. It recreates her behavior basing on recorded experience, but it is not guaranteed to be precisely accurate. You are shapening this magical creation by your power. It is bending to your will without restrictions from runestone."

It can't be. All of this can't be a lie. It can't be only Adora alone. These felling, these talks in the dark, this love is what...

-

"...Makes everything possible." Princess ended.

Catra grinned. "We are pretty attached." Bragging about it feels strangely pleasant. Maybe it because rebels look up to Adora so zealously, and blondie is sleeping with her. Or maybe it's normal when people have each other this way.

Hm. Rebel did know what Catra needed. Attacked her first, and wouldn't tell anything without threats, but this princess doesn't seem to be as self-righteous and spoiled as the one from Brightmoon. Lonely wait for Adora to show up does not that appealing to feline now.

"Are these wounds stuck forever?" It could happen to feline too, so asking won't hurt.

"Our bodies are only magical representation of our essence. Power of Heart-Blossom will mend me." Princess went back to the giant tree.

"Hey. About that..." Catra went silent.

"It is hard to control impulses. I understand. We are emotions without a vessel to contain them." Princess rest her palms on the magic stone. Cracks on her face are slowly shrinking. "Oh, ancestors, if *I* was trained to fight, these Evil Horde soldiers wouldn't get off so lightly."

"Although, I wouldn't mind if you apologize." Princess tilted her head to look at Catra. No, she not going to do it for a person she just met. Rebel turned away. "Guess, Horde don't teach manners."

"I belive it's never too late to learn." When last traces from claws vanished, woman approached feline and moved her hand forward. "My name is Flora. And yours?"

"Catra." That's a start.

Chapter End Notes

It never was purely ghost story. Explanation like this was going to happen later, but using Angella for less accurate describtion felt like dragging out without much reason for it.
And now we have chapter counter.
To readers who thought it was Perfuma in third chapter. You were right, but it changed.
Next few parts will be shorter.

We were

Chapter Notes

Finally caught what I wanted this chapter to be.
Illegible phrases do have sense, but they aren't important.

This is the rock bottom, Catra thinks to herself. Is she really that lonely to start seeking company of a dead princess?

Unfortunately, the answer seems yes.

It's not like other options are any better, though. Usual folks barely can interact with her and she won't be sitting around Krystal Castle, waiting for Adora to finish her training. This place gives her a creep.

Besides, by what Flora was telling her, it looks like Catra missed a lot of things out in the world. For example, what a person could be repulsed by the idea of fighting, let alone doing it? It's hard to believe. Plumerian princess not like this anymore, of course. And that feline can understand perfectly.

"But what about people under your command? Someone wanted their stuff and they what? Kept running away?" Catra can't help, but asks.

"We never needed much, nor did we have. And we always were happy to share with other kingdoms. No one had reasons to take our belongings by force." A few plumerians, which feline saw in Brightmoon are living in worn tents at random places in the city, they wore barely any cloth and behaved annoyingly cheerful. This match Flora's description.

"Before Horde came here."

"Before Evil Horde came here." Princess agreed. "That we could make wasn't enough for its hunger. We could provide only so little of that we were demanded for. Imagine, countless orchard's full of

fruits and wheat fields as far as you can see and it's still wouldn't be enough."

"It's not like I have ever seen that it is." Catra reminded.

"And you can't now." Flora's expression turns sad. "How people in Evil Horde can be so uncaring about destruction they create?"

"Strong do whatever they want to weak. That's how it works outside of «pacifistic» dreamworld." Catra shrugged. Flora glared at feline in the way, what makes her think it was a rhetorical question. "What? You, princesses, do the same thing. Your towers and palaces hadn't appeared from thin air. You took materials from someone weaker and made people without magic work for you."

"My family never had palace." Flora spoke sharply. "We were guiding our people the way we thought best for everyone. No one was forced do things they don't want. My people cared about each other's needs and it was always enough for us."

Catra feels how anger bubbles up inside her, threatening to flow over. "You are not alone in the world. Closing your eyes and pretending that everyone thinks the same way worked out so good for you."

"And your way did you any better?!"

"It made you tell me that I wanted to know from you, didn't it?!"

"You, heartless monster!"

"Brainless idiot!"

"Blind brute!"

"Dead dirty rat!"

"Ouch. This is low."

They both lashed out again. Princess hadn't joked about problem with holding back emotions for creatures of magic. With Adora it was hard, even considering lifelong experience doing it. With new faces, feline snaps in a moment. On the other hand, from such insignificant thing they come back just as fast. Insignificant in the «can't care less about that she is really thinking as long as she is talking» way.

"You were right." Older woman broke silence.

"Come again?"

"We shouldn't have closing off and behave like there is no problem." Flora continued a second later. "Now is your turn."

"Never." Catra only partially messing with the princess. Obeying request that easily also just goes against her very nature.

"I don't know if I am angry with you for your arrogance or if I feel sorry for you because of knowing from where you got it." Not-really-a-ghost quipped. "Try at least, you know, I can be patient. "

"You are not as bad as Brightmoon Queen." Catra gives up. Plumerian indeed better than her at waiting, she keeps silence after arguments until feline "try" to make amends. Lack of solid people around drove Catra up the walls, or trees in case of woods, for a long time. And having someone real within her reach, but still be seen through, is worse.

"Ancient hero She-ra, Brightmoon Queen and people from Evil Horde. You have a motley group of friends."

"More like people who won't or can't get rid of me right now than friends, but go on"

"Do you think She-ra can visit Plumeria? Not every day you learn that legends of the past turned out to be true." Princess brightened.

"I can't tell you for sure if she could come." Adora will be pissed if she finds out where Catra was. She needs to change the subject. "Hey, I recall you wanted to help me to figure out my runestone connection?"

Catra winced internally. Smooth, very smooth attempt. And she doubts this experience will be pleasant. Still, it might turn out to be useful.

"It would be a pity to miss opportunity to meet her." Flora changed her sitting position and gestured for Catra to join her. "I must warn you. All runestones are unique. What is working for me not necessarily will work for you."

"Then that's the point?"

"I can see why Scorpion's runestone accepted you." Flora puffed.

"And what this supposed to mean?"

"Nothing worth mentioning." Princess dismissively waved her hand. "If you do want my help, repeat after me."

"Put your legs like me, touch the ground with your hands, breath in. Concentrate on energy inside you and how it linked to the world." Catra hesitated, but followed instruction.

She feels it. The ground. Is hot, because leafage left to stop light rays. The air. Is abnormally thick with leftover poison. The energy. Is coming from the tool what inflicted fear and hate in her. The world.

Reasons to stay in which Catra doubts more and more.

"And for how long should I do it!" She managed to keep her intonation from giving out anything but irritation. It was stupid idea.

"If it not what you need, we can try to restore your lost memory of building connection." Princess doesn't look too happy herself

about that. "What the last thing you remember before *you returned*?"

The truth is what feline not sure. She had glimpses of her last life events at first and second day and actively stomped them down after. It was awful, so why think about it?

"I was in runestone's chamber? No." The memories are confusing. "No. Wait. There was something after."

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I regained my senses in one crushing moment. I just was in that damned chamber and now I am... here. The room full of metal tables with gray sheets on them. Judging by worse than usual illumination, this part of complex is below surface. Furniture in the room is similar to these in medbay, but chemicals smells in the air are like nothing I know. Nevertheless, it narrates my possible location.

As my disorientation fades, I am taking in more details. The source of screeching noise is a person on the other side of the room, who is standing with her back to me. The figure apparel blends in with dirty walls and grey color of the sheets. She puts away some tool and the noise stop. The person sighs and clouds of steam raise above her head.

Thing she is working on isn't the only one. Under grey cloth on others tables are laying similar objects. I am myself sitting on uncomfortable metal with the same sheet on my legs after it slide down when I jolted awake.

I need a plan. There is nothing left for me in Fright Zone. Taking Adora on her offer doesn't sounds that bad anymore. For it I have to leave Horde complex, starting from this room. I can come up with a way to infiltrate in rebels' territory later.

Vent grates in the room are at the ceiling, opening them would be loud. I don't know what witch planned for me next, so it's better

not be seen on my way out. To reach the door I should get past that medic. I soundlessly slip down on the floor. Medic is focused on her work, so sneaking behind her is easy. I reach for the tray with a bunch of tools to knock out the woman with it. When I about to grab the tray, red electric arc connects my hand and its metal surface. I instinctively brace for the pain, but it never came. Medic turned in the cracking sound direction. In panic, I point the arc at her. Lighting torrent eagerly bit down into new target. Woman fell on the floor with choked cry and stopped moving.

I staggered back. Leftover static is jumping between my fingers. Did the witch went overboard with her magic? After others punishments it never stayed after making a damage. Was it something else?

"Noitcnuflam buh tcerroc ot nesohc erew uoy. Eerht ytrof rebmun rotaredom." Crimson transparent scorpion woman appeared behind the table at which medic was working on.

My hands raised at sudden interruption and red lightings once again erupt from them, tearing newcomer apart until she dissipates.

I have to get out of here. Everything else can wait.

Red arc hit door button when I tried to push it. Smell of burned electronic filled air, door opened. Hallway next to the room isn't one of these I normally use, but sooner or later it must lead me to a place I could recognize or outside the building. The elevators I encounter on my way bring me only frustration. Magic kills its controls preventing me from taking a short route. The one with lift cabin on my level confirmed that I am underground and in medical facility as I initially thought. It gives me idea where staircase is.

Ceiling lamps are losing their brightness the closer I get to my destination. Shadows in far corners are growing bigger. When they started moving I already knew that it means. Witch is looking. It was one of her sick game from the begining. She let

me hope to make punishment more than just physically painful. Dozens of red eyes opened in shades. Her minions arrived to finish the job. Last lightbulb burned out. I bitterly smirk. Today Shadow Weaver not the only one with magic.

Magic is only good for one thing. The thing I have been training all my life to be best at.

To hurt.

Energy took off from my claws. Dark creatures squirm under torrents of power before being absorbed by the floor. Lamps are erratically light up and go off. It's not near enough. There are too many shades.

She won't feel it the way I want her to.

The more furious I become the more pressure I feel within. These lightnings are too weak for my rage. I hate her so much. Static charges are jumping on my outfit and fur. I am the source for it, not a target. This time others will be hurt by magic, not me.

Pressure build up to the point where it's overwhelming to bear. I release the power. My entire body radiates red energy. Web of thick bright lines are marking where electricity found the easiest route to whatever objects it ends up in. The explosion obliterates all living shadows. I hope the witch felt it. And that it was painful.

I am alone in dim hall once more. Good thing that the fight happened underground or half of Fright Zone would have known where I am. My plan was, and still is, to break in mechanical bay and steal a skiff unnoticed. It would have become difficult if all guards were out for my blood. Lightings, what were swirling in my hands are gone, so I don't have to worry that they can attract unwanted attention. Good riddance.

Medical facility has several connections to vehicle storage building, mostly on ground level. They are too crowded for my current situation. But there are a few bridges on upper levels, which are deserted all the time. It was interesting to watch from there how

strike teams depart for their mission. It feels like it was a lifetime ago.

I go higher without accidents. Power discharge in the basement destroyed facility's electric grid. Corridors deep in the building are empty and dark. Soldiers stick to outer ones while trying to find the reason for blackout. But the lack of light isn't a problem for me.

On fifth level I ran out of luck. Someone is hysterically shouting in the passage I wanted to walk through. It took me a moment to recognize who it is.

"I just don't understand why now of all the times!" Lonnie's voice is hoarse. "She had no troubles to screw us up and leave us to deal with everything by ourselves!"

"We all knew this could end badly! She knew it too! Just why she decided to come back!" Ah, she is talking about me. Normally, I would come to my squadmate and trashtalked her in return, but I have more pressing matters.

I carefully look around the corner. The rest of the squad is also here. Kyle is holding flashlight and supposedly illuminate fuse box. Rogellio had been tinkering with the said box, but now they both are looking at Lonnie.

"She always knew when to hide! Knew not to bite more than she can chew! Never ever once did something that haven't benefitted her or wasn't out of spite!" She is continuing her ranting.

"Then what she has tried to achieve by fucking dying?!" Cadet produced sound what is suspiciously resembling sob, if I hadn't known better.

"That!" She started kicking wall on every word. "Venomous! Selfish! Lazy! Bitch!!"

Lonnie finally shut up. I am ready to throw away what left of my self-control, when Kyle slowly approached her and hugged. And

lizard cadet joined them? Anyway, while they distracted by this weird scene, I take opportunity to move forward.

From the bridge I can see huge orange stain in the sky near horizon. It seems, I was out of it for a few hours after Shadow Weaver dragged me in her chamber.

"Rotatilicaf tcatnoc ot tpmetta. Nwonknu esuac noitcnuflam." On the other side of the bridge woman from before is waiting for me. **"Locotorp noitarotser dradnast htiw deecorp ot desivda si rotaredom. Noitcennoc hsilbatse ot elbanu. Tuo demit ksat."**

I can examine scorpion better while I am not actively freaking out. Her uniform isn't standard Horde issue and her figure is too angular. Some part of the woman hadn't set in place after last meeting. She is speaking nonsense again.

"What do you want from me?" At this rate I'll never escape from here.

"Ytilanoitcnuf buh erusne ot si ytud rotaredom." She says as if it means anything.

"Out of my way." I demand and push scorpion only to fall through her on the floor.

"Ugh." Witch really did a number on me. I was talking to a hallucination.

"Deyolped ed lliw erusaem yranilpicsid ro nruter. Noitacol detangised morf yawa evom ot dednemmocer ton si ti." Ignoring it is the best option.

I glare at entrance door's controls. Will it short circuit? I cautiously press it. Door slide up. As I step over the threshold, I feel like I am moving through the water, but unpleasant sensation quickly subsided.

"Detceted rorre eroc." The hallucination spoke from the outside.

From there I use the same route to get to vehicles as the day before. When I wasn't alone doing it. Keys stealing and returning part also wasn't on me. On second thought, she, perhaps, just walked in and took it as Force Captain.

Administrative room in the garage is my last stop before relative freedom. Survived drivers from the last raid should have already finish with checking in, so it leaves me only to deal with soldiers on shift. They are relaxed and outright slacking. Aftermath of the attack keeps commanders busy for time being and there are hours before their replacements arrive. I quietly crawl inside the room and grab the closest key chain.

So close to success it's hard to believe. I am actually doing it. I am running away from Fright Zone. My home. My prison. Leaving behind my greatest dreams and my worst fears.

This better be worth it.

The wind whistles on the road from the dead wasteland and when I cross treeline. The Woods can try to stop me. They will fail.

"Noisses noitacinummoc stseuqer Epoh Thgil rotatilicaf."

My grip on control lever is weakening.

"Dehsilbatse si noitcennoc."

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The memories were waiting for her to take them. As Catra suspected, they aren't good ones.

"Shadow Weaver knows what runestone connected with me!" Feline jumped on her feet and started pacing. Catra's plans were revolving around that witch had no idea about her real state. The

little bit of security she felt from the knowledge is gone. It's just gone again. "What she is going to do!?"

"Calm down." Flora, very wisely for a princess, chose not to come closer. "She had plenty of time to make her move, right?"

"You don't know her like do! If Shadow Weaver hadn't acted immediately as she got opportunity, she is preparing something worse!" Witch managed to bend runestone to her will with magic, can she do the same thing to feline? Were these shadows even real or it was Shadow Weaver trying to get into her head?

"Or you aren't letting her use Black Garnet to the full extent." Princesses are dense.

"The more reasons for Shadow Weaver to find a way to destroy me! Anything between her and even tiniest scrap of power is an obstacle meant to be eliminated!" Can Catra shoot lightings now? It helped. Maybe, she should just go into Fright Zone and electrocute witch to death.

"If she is so much of manic, why she hadn't come in person here to claim Heart Blossom?" This is. Reasonable. Witch would want to take it as fast as she could. And sending soldiers after it obviously hadn't worked. "As I said, calm down. When you are off balance, you can miss solution for your problem."

"You have any suggestions?" Feline is still very agitated. "Because you are next in line after me."

"I don't."

"Then shut up and back off me." Flora's face hardened at that, but she listened. Or princess got offended enough for one more round of who can keep silence longer.

There is something wrong with Black Garnet. Perhaps, Catra can mess up Flower's runestone too, so she could come with her and at least distract the witch. Feline glared at princess. Who she is

kidding? «Manifestation of magic» would be absolutely useless in a fight.

Rushing in by herself was a stray thought, born from desperation. Shadow Weaver certainly set up a trap, or somehow differently prepared for it.

Luring rebels into Fright Zone to make them deal with the witch for Catra isn't dumb tactic by itself. But Queen will skin feline afterward.

Shadow Weaver has one weak point. Adora would be able to get close to her. Horde doesn't know what her blondie is She-ra. Shadow Weaver wants her back. She won't let any rumors about it spread. And Adora doesn't fight out of princess form, chances what soldiers could recognize some cadet in giant warrior is slim. So, no risk of getting caught before finishing the deed. This plan has its flaws. Adora won't kill Shadow Weaver. She even might try to stop Catra from doing it.

Feline needs more information and better ideas for a solid plan. She has one shot in this and can't waste it.

Meanwhile other details from her escape also add up to a picture.

Light Hope definitely has something to do with her memory gap in Whispering Woods. It happened twice already. Being near Krystal Castle is only asking for trouble. Luckily, Adora has communication tablet, so feline can send her an excuse why she won't wait blondie there.

Catra had vanished from the clearing around runestone's tree and reappeared in Bow's workshop in Brightmoon palace. All damage caused by the arson was repaired. Various Horde tech, which Adora brought from her patrols in the Woods, organized in neat piles around the room. One half-dismantled spherical bot occupies its center.

Arrow boy store his testing tablet on workbench. The device trilled from its usual place as in response to Catra's presence. Bow

swiftly pulled himself from under the bot and went to check on it. Feline followed suit.

In the middle of the device's screen stylized icon of a cat's face is flaring up.

"Catra, can you answer if you are hearing me?" Boy looks satisfied with his tech. Too satisfied for Catra's liking. She consciously hid herself. Feline was doing all the time when Adora was meeting princess or the Queen, but she still doubted if it had any effect on the latest. The tabled, fortunately, got tricked. So, no way for most rebels to locate Catra if doesn't want it.

"Guess, she just passed by." Boy stepped away from the workbench returning to what he was previously doing.

Feline casually shoved hand into the device to send her messages. Cat's icon showed again along with the trill. She quickly closed the warning. Bow turned back.

"Catra, you are interfering with my tracker pad. It's acting up when you are close and I made an alarm for this case. Can we, please, talk?" He self-consciously putted hand on the back of his neck. "I'll start, okay? You are avoiding Glimmer and Angella, and with how you usually behave in the palace, it will not lead to anything good."

"Who do you think you are to tell me what to do?" The tablet echoed Catra's words. She bit her lips. This is bad. Now Arrow Boy is sure that his tech is working.

"I want to help you. Angella already strained her limits very far for you and for Adora. Glimmer and I, mostly me, honestly, believe that you can be better than Evil Horde tried to make you to be. Adora is already happier with you just being here. You have so much love for her, there is no need to be bitter to everyone else. We gave you a chance, maybe you will give us a chance too?" Bow weakly smiled. Effect of his speech was a little ruined as he was looking slightly away from where feline is standing.

"Don't go «oh so kind and generous rebels allowed you to exist» on me! I am here only because Queen would be upset what one of her pawns doesn't smile while doing dirty work for the Rebellion!" Catra is seething. "I am not one of *you*! Never could have been!"

She feels how hatred towards this particular rebel is pushing her to act. Her emotions want to unleash themselves. Catra knows a way to let them do it. And that will follow after it. Royals will take their revenge, if she loses control.

"Angella isn't keeping you for Adora alone." Yes, she must have known about feline's runestone connection from the begging. Counted to use it, probably.

That's it.

Power in her palm overcharged the tablet and it blew up sending sharp glass shards fly. Bow shielded his face with one arm and his bare abdomen with another. Several shallow cuts opened on boy's limbs.

Queen's terms were explicit. If Catra screw up, Angella will get her. Plain and simple. But she can't learn about it immediately. Catra has to strike first. Brightmooners magic comes from runestone of their own. With it out of the picture she is safe. How feline can smash it? All tech in the workshop is useless.

The tank. It is still out there.

Catra reappeared inside the vehicle. She drove it from its shelter near edge of the Woods. Gun barrel raised. Turned to its target. Feline pushed the button to fire. Engine turned off. Battle machine slammed down on the ground.

"No, no, no. No!" Batteries couldn't run out of power now!

Catra went to the rear part of cabin. She grabs accumulators. A little bit of the cursed magic is all she needs to survive next minutes. Lightings refuse to obey. Despair is looming over the girl.

"Work! Work, you, stupid! Work!" Catra is clawing at empty powercells. She is barely leaving traces.

"Work." Feline can't trust even herself in her state. Sometimes she almost normal, the next moment she is nothing more than a mist.

"Please." Please, just this once.

Catra curled up. She is about to find out if she can cry.

Time passed. No one came.

Undead girl gathered herself. She won't go down without a fight. Queen will not go away unscratched from it. Catra prepare to meet her.

Windows in the palace bloomed with light when moon reached the end of its journey for the day. One by one, they fade away.

Queen is taunting her, that's for sure. Arrow boy should have told Angella already how he got hurt.

Catra waits in vain rest of the night. This is feels wrong. She is missing something.

She just can't understand what.

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